RM2 ODL Qualitative Project Resources

Ashley Robertson & Wil Toivo

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Overview

In this book, you will find the resources you need to complete the qualitative project for your Research Methods 2 course.

We will work through the book step-by-step, linking to relevant sections on Moodle. However, as the resources are made available from the start, you will also have some flexibility to work at a pace that suits you.

You will become familiar with the book in Semester 1, as we will ask you to look at certain sections to accompany the lecture content. However, the book will become most relevant in Semester 2, when you complete your larger assignments.

You will find links to each chapter at the left hand side of the page, and then there will be links to each heading within a chapter at the right hand side.

Part I

Qualitative Project Information

1 Qualitative designs

In this chapter, we compare quantitative and qualitative research and then practise the ideas about theory from this week's lecture. These activities will help you make the shift from thinking in quantitative terms to thinking in qualitative terms.

Quantitative and qualitative research are two different ways of approaching research, and the data they produce is very different. Neither approach is inherently 'better' than the other, and the two approaches can also work well together.

Complete the activities below to practise the key differences between the two approaches (Activities 1 and 2) and the basics of theoretical perspectives (Activity 3).

1.1 Activity 1: Differences between qualitative and quantitative designs

Quantitative research generally…	Qualitative research generally…
uses numbers as data	uses meaning as data, usually expressed in words (e.g. interview transcripts), and sometimes images
is hypothesis-driven and deductive ('top-down'): it starts with a theory, narrows it into hypotheses and tests them	is exploratory, focused on research questions, and inductive ('bottom-up'): it starts with observations, looks for patterns and builds ideas or theory from them
looks for precise, testable answers to specific questions (limits are set in advance)	looks for rich, detailed knowledge of a topic area (no strict limits are set in advance)
focuses on cause and effect, with variables that are measured or manipulated	focuses on experience: naturally occurring beliefs, behaviours and narratives
uses standardised, structured measures (e.g. questionnaires, assessments)	uses flexible, often semi-structured, measures (e.g. interviews, focus groups, diaries)
is often quicker to collect and analyse, because methods are standardised and are not changed part-way through	is iterative and ongoing, and often takes longer; the focus can shift as participants raise unexpected ideas

Quantitative research generally…	Qualitative research generally…
focuses on generalisation: does what we find in a sample apply to a wider population?	does not usually focus on generalisation, because the context in which data are gathered matters (findings can still contribute to wider understanding)
uses large samples (a power analysis estimates the minimum number), with data typically presented at group level	uses small samples, with data that typically includes individual quotes from individuals
is based on the belief that the researcher can aim for objectivity; the researcher's values and experiences are seen as playing little or no part in the research process	is based on the belief that the researcher's subjective values and experiences are important; reflexivity is important and the researcher's experiences are likely to influence the research process

This table describes general tendencies, not strict rules, and there can be exceptions to this.

Look at the table above and write down answers for the following questions:

- What might a 'typical' quantitative study look like? What kind of data might be collected? What would be the aim of the study? What might your sample look like?
- What might a 'typical' qualitative study look like? What kind of data might be collected? What would be the aim of the study? What might your sample look like?
- What type of research question might be best answered with a quantitative design?
- What type of research question might be best answered with a qualitative design?

1.2 Activity 2: Research designs quiz

Choose whether a quantitative or qualitative design is most appropriate for each of the following studies. Why did you choose each option?

1. Angela is conducting a study exploring the experiences of people currently experiencing mental ill health. She is interested in a) better understanding what people with mental ill health experience day-to-day, and b) exploring the support mechanisms that are in place

This study is more likely to be:

- (A) Qualitative

- (B) Quantitative

Explain the answer

This study would be best conducted as a qualitative study - the researcher is interested in exploring the experiences of people

2. John is conducting a study where he is measuring whether the amount of sleep that children get is related to their cognitive performance in class. He asks the children to wear a sleep tracker to bed, so he can see when they are sleeping and when they are awake.

This study is more likely to be:

- (A) Qualitative
- (B) Quantitative

Explain the answer

This study would best be conducted as a quantitative study - the data will be quantified in numbers

3. Sally is conducting a study where she is interested in how children and their parents make sense of the violence they see on TV.

This study is more likely to be:

- (A) Qualitative
- (B) Quantitative

Explain the answer

This study would best be conducted as a qualitative study – Sally is interested in how people understand and make sense of what they see (their beliefs and experiences), rather than in measuring a cause and its effect. The same topic could be studied quantitatively with a different research question. For example, if Sally asked whether the amount of violent TV that children watch predicts how aggressively they behave, she would be testing a relationship between measured variables, which is typical of quantitative research. The research question, not the topic, tells you which tool to pick.

4. James is conducting a study where he wants to better understand motivations for smoking among teenagers.

This study is more likely to be:

- (A) Qualitative

- (B) Quantitative

Explain the answer

This study would probably best be conducted as a qualitative study - the researcher is looking at the motivations of the participants. However, it could also possibly be a quantitative study, if the motivations are measured and quantified on a numeric scale instead of text data.

5. Elaine is conducting a study exploring whether the amount of studying done in preparation for an exam predicts exam performance.

This study is more likely to be:

- (A) Qualitative

- (B) Quantitative

Explain the answer

This study would be quantitative – Elaine is testing a specific, predefined question about the relationship between two measured variables (amount of studying and exam performance), and wants a precise, testable answer. Qualitative designs are not typically used to test relationships between measured variables.

1.3 Activity 3: Thinking about theory

In the mini-lecture on theoretical perspectives, we covered epistemology and ontology, as well as three types of knowledge that qualitative researchers can aim to produce (realist, phenomenological and social constructionist).

1.3.1 Part A: Two big questions

- **Epistemology** asks: how, and what, can we know?
- **Ontology** asks: what is there to know?

For each statement below, decide whether it is mainly about ontology (what there is to know), epistemology (how, and what, we can know), or both. Choose your answer first, then open the explanation.

1. 'There is one single reality, and it exists whether or not anyone studies it.'

This statement is mainly about:

- (A) Ontology
- (B) Epistemology
- (C) Both

Explain the answer

Ontology. This is a claim about what exists and what reality is like. It is a realist position.

2. 'The researcher and the participants are connected, and the researcher's values and experiences shape what the research finds.'

This statement is mainly about:

- (A) Ontology
- (B) Epistemology
- (C) Both

Explain the answer

Epistemology. This is a claim about how knowledge is produced. It is the constructionist idea that 'as we change, truth changes'. It links to reflexivity: if the researcher helps to shape the findings, they need to be open about their own values (we will cover this later in the course).

3. 'Reality depends on how people understand it, so there are multiple realities.'

This statement is mainly about:

- (A) Ontology

- (B) Epistemology

- (C) Both

Explain the answer

Ontology. Again, this is a claim about what exists: here, that there is more than one reality. It is a relativist position.

4. 'There is a real world, but we can only ever know it partially, because our experiences and perspectives shape how we see it.'

This statement is mainly about:

- (A) Ontology

- (B) Epistemology

- (C) Both

Explain the answer

Both. The first half is about what exists (a reality exists), which is ontology. The second half is about what we can know of it (only partially), which is epistemology. This is critical realism, which sits between realism and relativism

5. 'Researchers can produce objective knowledge by using observation, experiments and logic.'

This statement is mainly about:

- (A) Ontology

- (B) Epistemology

- (C) Both

Explain the answer

Epistemology. This is a claim about how we can know, and what counts as knowledge. It is the positivist idea that 'the truth is out there' to be uncovered by the researcher.

1.3.2 Part B: One topic, three types of knowledge

Three researchers are all interested in homesickness among first-year international students. Each one wants to produce a different type of knowledge. Remember the three types and their images from the lecture:

- Realist knowledge: the researcher as detective
- Phenomenological knowledge: the researcher as person-centred counsellor
- Social constructionist knowledge: the researcher as architect

Read each research question below. Which type of knowledge is it aiming to produce? Which words in the question gave you a clue?

1. How is homesickness constructed in the way international students talk about missing home?

This research question aims to produce:

- (A) Realist knowledge
- (B) Phenomenological knowledge
- (C) Social constructionist knowledge

Explain the answer

Social constructionist (the architect). The question is about how students talk, not about what homesickness 'really' is. It assumes that missing home could be described in many ways, and asks how one version is built and what it does. Clue: 'constructed in the way … talk'.

2. What processes do international students go through when they feel homesick during their first term?

This research question aims to produce:

- (A) Realist knowledge
- (B) Phenomenological knowledge
- (C) Social constructionist knowledge

Explain the answer

Realist (the detective). The question assumes that homesickness is something real that happens to students regardless of the researcher's or the participants' views, and that the researcher can identify the processes involved by asking the right questions and treating accounts as reports of what happened. Clue: 'what processes … go through'."

3. What is the lived experience of homesickness for international students in their first semester?

This research question aims to produce:

- (A) Realist knowledge
- (B) Phenomenological knowledge
- (C) Social constructionist knowledge

Explain the answer

Phenomenological (the person-centred counsellor). The focus is on the participants' own experience: how homesickness feels and what it means to them. The researcher is not trying to explain what mighty cause homesickness or determine whether homesickness is 'real'. Clue: 'lived experience'.

It is important to note that these wordings are to provide examples for you, but - in reality - they won't fall so neatly into these categories. Real research questions are often less tidy, and real research will often sit between these types. However, hopefully this exercise allows you to see the differences between the knowledge that each approach aims to produce, and that this difference is mirrored in the way the RQs are phrased.

2 Qualitative questions

The purpose of this chapter is to get you thinking about how to formulate good questions for different qualitative research methods, and what things to avoid. Do the activities below on your own and then discuss your answers with your group.

2.1 Focus Groups

When you are conducting qualitative research, thinking about the questions you are going to ask your participants is really important to ensure your data will be rich and of good quality. You want to write questions that are clear, open-ended and prompt the participants to discuss/share their experiences. Here are ten tips for writing good focus group questions:

1. Ensure that the questions on your Focus Group Schedule are relevant and allow you to explore and possibly answer your research questions.
2. Remember you are not doing quantitative research! The beauty of qualitative research is that your participants can respond in a variety of ways and tell you all about their experiences. In order to allow them to do this, don't ask them questions, such as: Do people like A more than B? Does one thing cause another?
3. Make sure that your questions are open-ended, such as: What are your experiences of… , Can you think of a situation when…? This will keep conversation going. Don't ask questions that prompt a simple yes/no answer.
4. Don't write questions that are leading e.g. Do you agree that…. You are investigating something you don't know the answer to. Even if you think you might know the answer your questions should not reflect this.
5. Think about ethics! Are the questions you are asking people ethically problematic? If they are, it doesn't always mean you should not ask them, you just have to be more cautious when you do - it's important that we respect our participants and give them the opportunity to decide how much they are willing to share!
6. Think about time. Focus groups often last around 30-40 mins. It takes quite a bit of time to get through a focus group schedule, especially if you have to ask additional questions. We would recommend you have 5 or maybe 6 questions/discussion points on your schedule.

7. It is useful to put a star next to/highlight the really important questions you want to ask. This means that if you do start to run out of time then you can miss some of the other questions and go straight to these questions.
8. Think about the order of the questions on the schedule. You want to create a discussion that is as natural as possible, and this means one question should follow from the next. If you structure the questions well at this point you may find that in the focus group you have to say very little in order to cover everything.
9. Have an opening question that makes people feel relaxed and gets them talking. Something that people can discuss easily and something they don't need to think about too much.
10. Additional prompts underneath the questions can be helpful for the person running the focus group, especially when you are new to qualitative research. See the Interviews section below for an example from a study Ashley was involved with a few years ago. So, think of some probing questions that might allow people to discuss the question/topic in more detail. You might not have to use these, but they are there if you do!

2.2 Interviews

Many of the rules for good focus group questions also apply to interviews (e.g. writing open-ended questions that are not leading, having prompts ready etc.). However, in an interview, the researcher is typically one-on-one with a participant, which means that the discussion may in some cases be a bit less structured than a focus group schedule and may need to include more probes.

This is one section from a semi-structured interview schedule Ashley conducted, and is provided purely to give an example of how you might follow up your questions with prompts or probes. Please note that these were sensitive interviews that required NHS ethical approval, and therefore will likely be very different to any research you will be doing during the ODL course in terms of content/tone.

Questions about receiving anxiety interventions	PROBES
What help have you received for your anxiety?	What help did you receive in the past? Are you currently receiving help? Who helps/helped you?
Do you feel as if the help you received (or are receiving) has made any difference to your anxiety? It may have made a positive difference, a negative difference or no difference at all.	Anything else?
What was the best thing about the help you received for your anxiety?	How did it help? Anything else?

Questions about receiving anxiety interventions	PROBES
What was the worst thing about the help you received for your anxiety?	Can you expand on this? Anything else?
What, in your opinion, would have helped the most when receiving help for your anxiety?	Why would this have helped? Anything else?
Some interventions will be adapted for the specific needs of the client. Did the help you received seem to be modified in any way? If so, what changes were made, in your opinion?	If there were changes, were they helpful? What helped the most? If any changes at all could have been made, what would your suggestions be?
If someone was to develop an intervention to help autistic adults with their anxiety, what would help the most, in your opinion?	What would be the best type of intervention? What changes should be made? What information could you give that would help the person giving the intervention?

Note: the original schedule used the term 'adults with ASD'. We have updated this to identity-first language ('autistic adults'), which many autistic people prefer.

2.3 Qualitative surveys

Many of the principles discussed above also apply to qualitative survey questions - you want your questions to be clear, qualitative, and open-ended. However, due to the different response format and the fact that you are not there to clarify or provide prompts, there are some additional things to take into account when designing qualitative surveys. Here are some tips for writing good qualitative survey questions:

1. You don't get instant feedback from your participants the same way you do in focus groups or interviews - hence, it's really important to ensure your questions are clear before starting data collection. Pre-testing the questions with people who are not involved in the project is a good way to do this.
2. Clarity of the questions is particularly important - make sure there is no ambiguity and keep your questions short.
3. Avoid questions which have multiple parts (as participants may just pick up on one) - if your question has multiple parts, it might be better to split it into two

4. Think of the order of your questions - if you start with a broad, over-arching question, participants might only answer this question and write "see above" in others, which reduces the richness of your data
5. You can provide examples in brackets after the question that work as "prompts" and help the participant answer the question. However, be careful not to steer them too much or assume what their answer will be. In a recent qualitative survey that Wil conducted, this was one of the questions: "What do you think language barriers in teaching are, and what are your experiences (and/or those of your colleagues) of them in teaching international students? (Here you may want to reflect on your experience of teaching, tutoring, supervising and interacting with international students.)"
6. Include a final open question that allows the participant to share anything they would like to add. For example: "Is there anything else you would like to add about … ?"
7. Don't include too many main questions - this will reduce the quality of your data as participants will get tired and more likely to drop out (you may have some demographic questions which are shorter and that's fine).

2.4 Activities

2.4.1 Activity 1: Which of these questions would you change and why?

Have a look at these fictional focus group questions and write down which ones you would change and why.

Research question: How does students' sense of belonging relate to participation in team sports?

1. How many hours of group sport do you participate in each week?
2. What does being a part of a team mean to you?
3. What does belonging mean to you?
4. How has your sense of belonging improved since joining your sports team?
5. I am going to go around the group one-by-one and I want everybody to tell me about a time when they felt that they haven't belonged to a team, and how that impacted them personally?
6. Tell me on a scale from 1-5, how much do you feel like you belong to a sports team
7. Do you like being part of a sports team?

Suggested Answers

- **Question 1.** This question will result in a numeric answer that does not produce meaningful qualitative data. Be careful not to accidentally ask quantitative

questions!

- **Question 2. and 3.** These two questions are open-ended and qualitative, and will likely provide rich answers. One thing to think about is what question to start with and where to include prompts - number 3 is quite big and vague, and participants may struggle to get started with this, especially if it's early on in the focus group (FG).
- **Question 4.** This is a leading question - it implies that their sense of belonging has indeed *improved* when this may not be the case. A better way to phrase this would be: **"Has your sense of belonging changed since joining a team? If so, how? If not, why not?"**
- **Question 5.** This question puts participants on the spot, which is something you never want to do, especially with a sensitive question like this. Instead, the question should be given to the group, so participants can answer if they want to, and disclose as much or as little as they wish to.
- **Question 6.** This is a quantitative question and does not provide meaningful qualitative data.
- **Question 7.** This is a yes/no-question. You should avoid phrasing questions like this, as they don't prompt rich answers. Instead, you may want to ask something like: **"What has been the best part about joining a team and why?** or **What aspects of being part of a team do you like? Why?** If you ask a yes/no-question, make sure to follow it up with prompts (e.g. "If so, how? If not, why not?", as in the suggested answer for Question 4).

2.4.2 Activity 2: Re-wording questions

Have a look at these poorly written fictional focus group questions. Try to re-write them to improve them for clarity and the quality of data they would give you.

Research question: Exploring international students' experiences of their sense of belonging and homesickness

1. Have you ever felt homesick while studying abroad?
2. How has this negatively affected you?
3. How often do you feel like you don't belong?
4. Does homesickness ever make you feel like you don't belong?
5. What do you do to feel better?

When you are happy with your own answers, go through the suggested answers below.

Suggested Answers

- Question 1: This question prompts a yes/no answer - a better way to phrase this would be: **"What have your experiences of homesickness been while studying abroad?"**
- Question 2: This question can be a bit sensitive - a better way to phrase this would be to say **"How do you think this has affected you?"** so the participant doesn't feel like they need to share a negative experience if they don't want to. Alternatively you could ask: **"What about this has been challenging to you and how have you managed that?"**
- Question 3: This question doesn't produce meaningful qualitative data - if they answer "Mostly on weekends", you don't have much to analyse. A better way of phrasing the same idea would be: **"Can you tell me about times you have, or haven't, felt a sense of belonging while studying here?"**
- Question 4: This question also prompts a yes/no answer. This is not necessarily a very good question in the first place because you're not directly looking at a causal relationship the same way you would in a quantitative study, and it can easily become a leading question assuming there is a relationship between the two. A better question would be: **"How do you think your experiences of belongingness and homesickness compare or connect to each other?"**
- Question 5: This question is a bit ambiguous and it's not really clear what you are asking - feel better about what? This also assumes that homesickness is always a negative state, which it might not be to the participants. A better way to phrase this would be: **"How do you like to manage your feelings of homesickness?"** or **"What do you do when you are feeling homesick?"**

If you are planning a qualitative dissertation, Ashley's optional research skills session on developing questions in Appendix B goes into this in more depth.

3 Data collection

This chapter runs through some of the practical issues you need to think about when collecting data for a qualitative study. Do the activities below on your own and then discuss your answers with your group.

3.1 Considering ethics

Informed consent

Before and data collection takes place, you must provide your participants with an information sheet and consent form. You can find more information about this in the Ethics, Rigour and Reflexivity chapter.

You must give everyone participating the Information sheet and consent form before the focus group/interview takes place. Completed consent forms should be returned to the researcher and you should verbally confirm consent before you start any data collection. In a survey, participants should complete consent form before seeing any survey questions.

Confidentiality in Focus groups

Remember that everyone (both those participating and running) the focus group have a responsibility to maintain confidentiality of the discussion.

Discuss some 'ground rules' at the start with the group, and also go through the Information Sheet and consent form at the start, to ensure everyone is aware of their responsibilities. You may also want to include an ice breaker to make your participants feel more comfortable.

3.2 Focus group structure

There are a number of stages to a focus group, and it's not always exactly the same, but here is an example structure for a focus group:

- **Stage 1: Setting the scene.** The topic of the project should be introduced by the facilitator, and everyone agrees to take part. It must be made clear to the people in your focus group a) that they do not have to answer any questions that they do not feel comfortable with, b) highlight that the session will be recorded (if conducting your study online, also make sure to let your participants know they have a choice to have their camera on or off, but that the mic must be used), c) what will happen with the recordings (i.e. that they will be kept safe on University-approved servers and the transcript anonymised), d) that everyone has a responsibility to maintain confidentiality of the topics discussed in the group and e) that they are free to leave the session at any time. Run through the Information Sheet and Consent Form here, and discuss any ground rules you have. I would also raise the point here that there are a few questions to get through, and therefore you might have to step in to help manage time.
- **Stage 2: Recording.** Remember to start recording and let your participants know when you do it. This is very important.
- **Stage 3: Introductions.** Go around the table and ask everyone to introduce themselves. Start with yourself and the note-taker first. Everyone should state their first name clearly.
- **Stage 4: Ice-breaker.** Ask a warm-up question or ice-breaker. The aim is to allow participants to introduce themselves, ensure everyone understands the procedure, and to encourage people to feel comfortable talking. Previous projects have used photos, cartoons, and media, or asked participants to generate meanings of the terms used in the discussion (e.g., "poor sleep","well-being") to get people talking.
- **Stage 5: Discussion.** This is where you ask your main questions, and follow-up questions. It is a good idea to prepare around five or six main questions, and perhaps highlight three or four that are most important to focus on. The discussion may follow a different order to that on the focus group schedule - this is fine.
- **Stage 6: Facilitating the discussion.** The facilitator should be prepared to help steer conversation back on track, and balance discussion so that everyone gets a chance to contribute. Have a few specific prompts that relate to each question and/or some general prompts to keep the discussion flowing. What are you going to do if no-one participates? Or if one person is contributing? For example… "has anyone else had a similar experience? Does anyone have a different view?" At the same time be ethical and avoid targeting individual people. Give participants the opportunity to describe their interpretations and take ownership. E.g., "How would…make you feel", "Have you ever noticed that…" "Think back to when…", "What was most important to you about…?"
- **Stage 7: Ending the discussion.** It's good to end the discussion by going round the group and asking each participant if they have anything they want to add to the discussion/sum up their thoughts on what was discussed.Remember to allow focus group members the chance to confirm/withdraw consent for their anonymised contributions to be used.

3.3 Facilitation and note-taking

Facilitation/moderation

The facilitator (sometimes also known as the moderator) will be the person taking the lead during the focus group. They will be the one asking the questions of the participants, and the one facilitating the discussion. As you are aiming to mimic a naturalistic conversation, you have to build rapport. Ensure you allow everyone time to introduce themselves, and contribute to the ice-breaking phase by saying a bit about yourself.

A good facilitator shares the perspective of the people they are talking to throughout the focus group. The moderator should not be listening out for good quotes and should not be thinking about what to analyse. The role of the facilitator is to listen to the participants, and understand their points of view.

Note-taking

It is a good idea to have a note-taker there. Hopefully there will be no IT issues that mean that the recording doesn't work! Therefore, the note-taker should remind the facilitator about recording if required, and note down any impressions/initial thoughts around themes/good quotes. Also, you could note down how well the questions worked - were there any that participants didn't understand? It should be clear from the recording who is contributing when; it is useful to note down here and there who is speaking at various points, to ensure it matches up later on.

3.4 Facilitating focus groups: How to manage the group?

Focus groups are designed to be an informal discussion in a moderated setting. This allows for the data collection to be flexible and occur in a collective, more natural way - however, moderating a discussion in a group setting can also be challenging. Below we have some top tips for how to manage focus groups.

1. Make sure your participants are comfortable: establish ground rules and expectations at the start, ensure that you are interested in their perceptions and experiences and that there are no right or wrong answers, start with an ice-breaker to warm your participants up and make sure nobody is put on the spot and participants don't feel pressured to answer anything they do not wish to answer.
2. Manage the conversation effectively: make sure all participants have the opportunity to contribute if they wish and one participant doesn't dominate the whole conversation, ensure that conversation doesn't stray off topic or get stuck on one topic for too long. Give prompts if the participants struggle to get started on a question.

3. Stay neutral and *listen*: be careful not to provide your own opinion or views (this is surprisingly easy to do accidentally!) - this is about your participants and their experiences. Focus on listening to the participants and clarifying/prompting further if needed, give your participants time to gather their thoughts (learn to be comfortable with silent moments and don't fill them in with your opinions).

View below some situations you may encounter when running a focus group: before checking the answer, have a think how you would manage these scenarios and discuss the answers with your group.

1. One/some participants are very quiet and one participant dominates the conversation

Suggested Solutions

- The ice-breaker/easy opening questions are perhaps most important for quieter members of the group, to help make them feel more comfortable.
  - If you are running the focus group online, it might be a good idea to use the Raise hand feature - this would allow quieter members to show that they want to contribute, but without trying to gauge when to jump in the conversation. You can then take points in order of when they raised their hands.
  - If some people have contributed to part of the discussion and others haven't, open it up to the rest by asking if anyone who hasn't responded yet has anything to add. However, don't put people on the spot by asking them directly.
  - Make sure to distribute turns equally

2. The discussion is stuck on one topic

Suggested Solutions

- Remind the members of the group that there are a number of different questions to explore, and that you are mindful of time, so it might be best to leave that topic for now, and you can return if there's time at the end.

3. The discussion goes off topic

Suggested Solutions

- The facilitator has to be mindful of this and be ready to steer the conversation back on topic if needed.
- Remind the members of the group that there are a number of different questions to explore, and that you are mindful of time.
- Gently remind participants of the question that was asked. If running the FG

online, you may wish to put your questions on the chat or present them with screen sharing so the participants can see the question.

4. Participants are not comfortable answering the questions in the language the focus group is conducted in

Suggested Solutions

- Send questions in advance to your participants so they can prepare
- Consider if the FG could be conducted in a different language (however, be mindful that this creates additional work with transcription and translations and requires the facilitator to be fluent in the language)
- Give participants time to think and answer, and focus on making everybody feel comfortable at the start of the FG.

5. One participant looks uncomfortable and does not contribute

Suggested Solutions

- Try to create opportunities for everybody to speak, but remember that you should not point fingers at individual participants
- You cannot force anybody to speak, and sometimes participants might feel uneasy.
- Remember that they don't need to answer any of the questions if they don't want to - it is unethical to force your participants to answer.

6. Nobody answers the question you asked

Suggested Solutions

- Remember that this is the first time the participants may see the question, and they may need time to gather their thoughts
- Consider sending questions to your participants in advance so they know what to expect.
- Don't be uncomfortable with a bit of awkward silence (particularly if running your FG online) and don't fill the space with your opinions - let the participants take the lead.
- Prepare prompts/probes that you can ask to help the participants get started.
- You can ask if anybody would like to go first (don't put an individual participant on the spot)

7. You are not sure what the participant meant/the participant answers very shortly

Suggested Solutions

- You can ask if the participant would like to clarify the aspect of the answer you are not sure about.
- You can ask the participant to elaborate further (they may not want to, which is fine!). If you do this, make sure that you are specific about what you want them to elaborate on (for example, "that's really interesting, would you want to tell me a little bit more about why you think XXX?)
- If the participant does not know how to elaborate, you can ask if anybody else wants to add anything. Sometimes this will prompt the participant to build on their answer as a response to what the other participants are saying.

3.5 Facilitating interviews

Interviews are very different to focus groups, as the data collection is typically set up in a one-on-one situation. This means the types of questions you should ask, the types of answer you are likely to get, and the practical issues are quite different to focus groups. Here are some top tips for how to conduct an interview.

- Make an effort to develop rapport and make the participant feel comfortable.
- If you are doing a sensitive topic, pay attention to how your participant is presenting and ask them if they need a break or if they would like to continue.
- Focus on the person rather than taking notes - are you giving them encouragement to keep speaking (e.g. nods etc.)?
- If doing a semi-structured interview, pay attention to whether the participant brings something up that could/should be followed up with an addional question
- Not all interviews will be the same length - some people are very concise in how they answer whereas others talk a lot more so the overall interview length will vary
- Try to end on a positive question if you can - it can help to lift the mood for the participant and leave them in a good place

3.6 GDPR-compliance and data management

GDPR: general data protection regulation. It is the most up to date data protection law and your data collection and storage must comply to the GDPR principles.

See the University guidelines on:

- handling confidential data

The University's Data Protection and Freedom of Information office also has useful information on how to manage data.

Make sure that:

- You have a data management plan in place before data collection (how and where are you storing the data, who will have access to it, how long do you need to store it for, what steps of confidentiality and anonymisation are you taking?)
- Participants are made aware of your data management plan prior to any data collection in the information sheet and consent form
- Data should be retained until after completion of the project on a password-protected encrypted drive and a secure database accessible only to the research team
- Only use University-approved systems to collect, manage and store data - **do not use external providers (such as Google or Dropbox)**, as they may not be GDPR compliant
- If you share the data, your participants should be informed about this prior to taking part, and you should only share the anonymised data files
- **Do not share data via social media, Google drive or personal email which is not secure.**

If you are planning a qualitative dissertation, Ashley's optional research skills session on data collection in Appendix B goes into this in more depth.

4 Data analysis

This chapter has activities to support you with Thematic Analysis. This chapter, alongside Ashley's lectures, will talk you through the six phases required for TA; we advise using Braun & Clarke (2021) to structure your data analysis. This can be accessed through the library.

Overview of the steps of TA

1. Familiarisation (p.42 in the Braun & Clarke (2021) book)
2. Doing coding (p.59)
3. Generating initial themes (p.78)
4. Developing and Reviewing themes (p.97)
5. Refining, Defining and Naming themes (p.108)
6. Writing up your analysis (p.118)

> ! Before you start: a key principle
>
> **Themes do not emerge.** It is common to read that themes 'emerged' from the data. This suggests that themes are lying in wait for you to discover them, and that any analyst would find the same ones. This is not the case: you actively develop your themes, and your experiences, assumptions and interpretations will affect the themes you end up with. This is why reflexivity matters throughout your analysis, not just at the end (see Chapter 5).

4.1 Coding (Phases 1-2)

Here, we'll focus on Phases 1 and 2 of the process. We also covered how to do Phases 1 and 2 of the analysis in the Thematic Analysis lecture in Semester 1.

4.1.1 Phase 1: Familiarisation (p.42)

- Transcribing (or correcting/anonymising your transcript) helps you to become more familiar with your data. You will not do this in this project, but you might during your dissertation.

- Read over the transcript, but do it in an 'active' way. This means reading while searching for meanings and patterns
- Note down anything of interest that comes up, either in a particular part of a transcript or thinking about the overall dataset.

Practical Steps

Read through your transcript and take notes and/or make comments in the margins. Generate a list of ideas: what is interesting about the discussion? Are there any contradictions that you spot? What patterns do you observe?
Also note your own responses to the data (e.g. how do you feel when you read it?), and try to unpick the assumptions behind them:

- What was familiar?
- What was unfamiliar/surprising?
- Why are you reacting to the data in that way?

4.1.2 Phase 2: Coding (p.59)

- Codes identify a feature of the data that seems interesting or relevant to your research question
- The process of coding involves going through the transcript and thinking about the data, and picking out what seems interesting/important.
- Try to apply short, specific labels to each part of the transcript as you go through it.
- Codes are specific, and each one usually captures a single idea (themes, which come later, are broader and capture a pattern of shared meaning) – you will likely end up with quite a lot of different codes.
- Code as much of the relevant data as you can at this point – not every code will make it to the next stage, but it's good to capture as much as you can now.

Practical Steps

Insert labels beside quotes – what is interesting about the quote? What does it tell us in relation to your research question?

4.1.3 Semantic and latent codes

When you code, you can work at different levels of meaning:

- *Semantic* codes capture meaning that is explicitly expressed. They stay close to the participants' own words and the surface meaning of the data. Semantic coding still goes beyond summarising or paraphrasing.
- *Latent* codes capture deeper, more implicit meaning: the underlying ideas, assumptions and concepts behind what is said.

Semantic and latent are two ends of a continuum rather than a strict choice, and many analyses include both. You can see both levels in Braun & Clarke's notes on the Andreas extract in the optional research skills session (Appendix B): their first notes stay close to what he says, and they then look 'a bit more deeply' at what might lie underneath.

Two related ideas are easy to mix up with semantic and latent:

- **Inductive and deductive coding** is about where your codes come from: the data itself (more inductive) or existing theory you bring to it (more deductive).
- **The type of knowledge your study aims to produce** (see Chapter 1) is also separate: a realist study can include latent codes, and a social constructionist study can include semantic ones.

4.1.3.1 What do Braun & Clarke say about semantic and latent codes?

If you want to explore this in more detail, Braun & Clarke talk about the differences between semantic and latent coding, and provide examples of descriptive and analytical coding, in Braun and Clarke (2013) p207-210 and also p252-254.

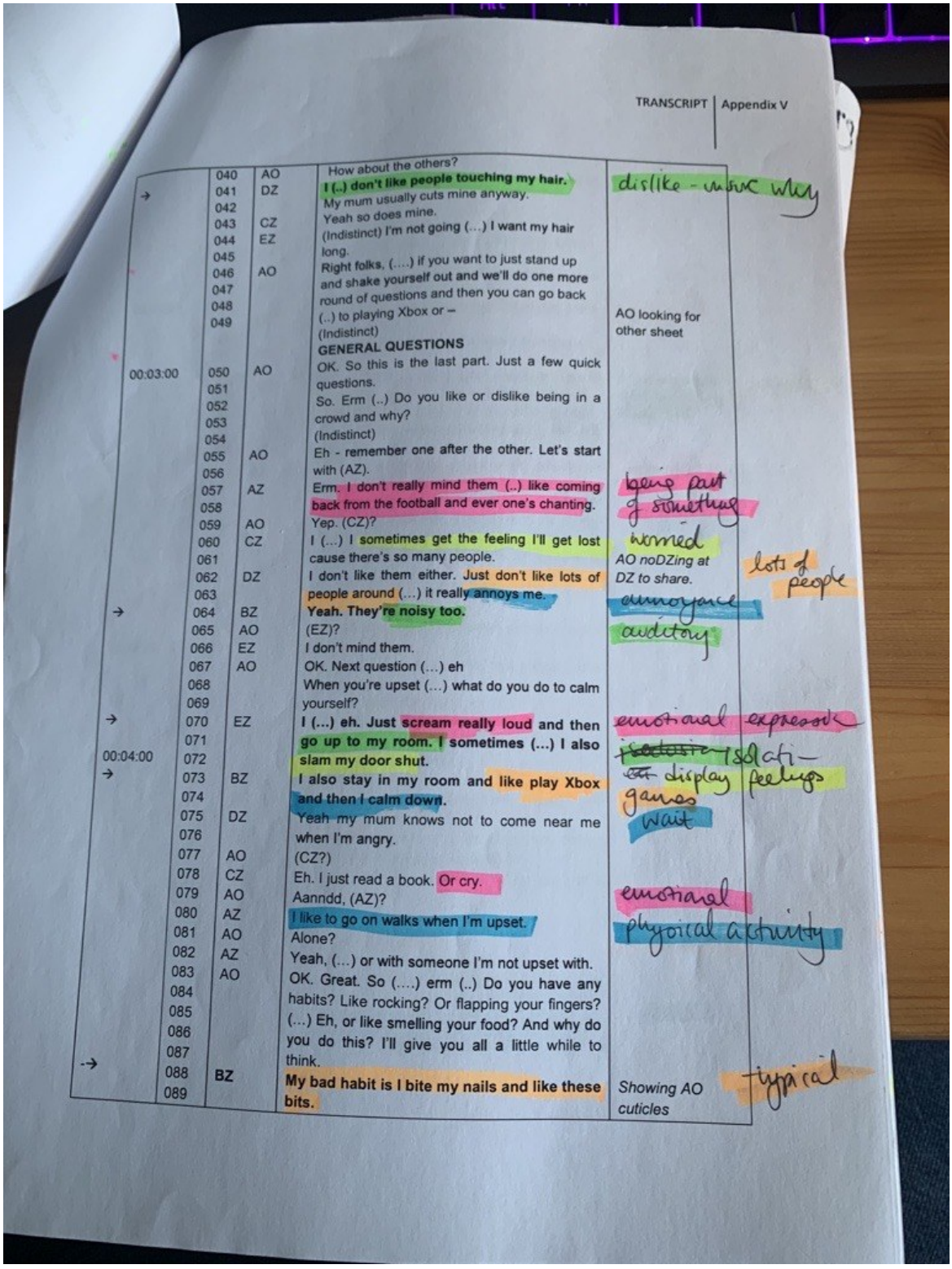
4.1.4 How to actually do the coding (logistically)?

There are many different ways to approach this. Below are two examples of how you might approach it: hand-coding and using comments on Word.

Option 1: Hand-coding

Option 2: Code using Word, by adding comments

If you do a qualitative project for your dissertation, lots of other options will be open to you, so please do ask your supervisor what might be best!



TRANSCRIPT | Appendix V

	040	AO	How about the others?	
→	041	DZ	**I (..) don't like people touching my hair.**	dislike - unsure why
	042		My mum usually cuts mine anyway.	
	043	CZ	Yeah so does mine.	
	044	EZ	(Indistinct) I'm not going (…) I want my hair long.	
	045			
	046	AO	Right folks, (….) if you want to just stand up and shake yourself out and we'll do one more round of questions and then you can go back (..) to playing Xbox or –	
	047			
	048			
	049		(Indistinct)	AO looking for other sheet
			GENERAL QUESTIONS	
00:03:00	050	AO	OK. So this is the last part. Just a few quick questions.	
	051			
	052		So. Erm (..) Do you like or dislike being in a crowd and why?	
	053			
	054		(Indistinct)	
	055	AO	Eh - remember one after the other. Let's start with (AZ).	
	056			
	057	AZ	Erm. I don't really mind them (..) like coming back from the football and ever one's chanting.	being part of something
	058			
	059	AO	Yep. (CZ)?	
	060	CZ	I (…) I sometimes get the feeling I'll get lost	worried
	061		cause there's so many people.	AO noDZing at DZ to share.
	062	DZ	I don't like them either. Just don't like lots of	lots of people
	063		people around (…) it really annoys me.	annoyance
→	064	BZ	**Yeah. They're noisy too.**	auditory
	065	AO	(EZ)?	
	066	EZ	I don't mind them.	
	067	AO	OK. Next question (…) eh	
	068		When you're upset (…) what do you do to calm	
	069		yourself?	
→	070	EZ	**I (...) eh. Just scream really loud and then**	emotional expressive
	071		**go up to my room. I sometimes (...) I also**	~~isolation~~ isolation
00:04:00	072		**slam my door shut.**	~~eh~~ display feelings
→	073	BZ	**I also stay in my room and like play Xbox**	games
	074		**and then I calm down.**	wait
	075	DZ	Yeah my mum knows not to come near me	
	076		when I'm angry.	
	077	AO	(CZ?)	
	078	CZ	Eh. I just read a book. Or cry.	
	079	AO	Aanndd, (AZ)?	emotional
	080	AZ	I like to go on walks when I'm upset.	physical activity
	081	AO	Alone?	
	082	AZ	Yeah, (…) or with someone I'm not upset with.	
	083	AO	OK. Great. So (….) erm (..) Do you have any	
	084		habits? Like rocking? Or flapping your fingers?	
	085		(…) Eh, or like smelling your food? And why do	
	086		you do this? I'll give you all a little while to	
	087		think.	
→	088	BZ	**My bad habit is I bite my nails and like these**	Showing AO cuticles
	089		**bits.**	typical

Figure 4.1: Example of a hand-coded transcript

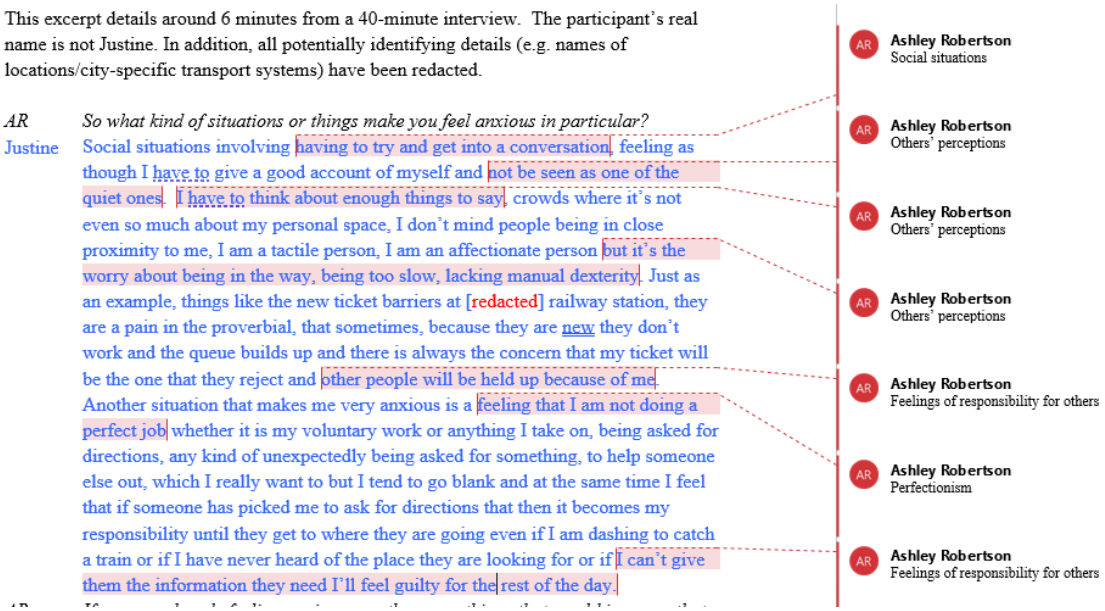


Figure 4.2: Example of a transcript coded using comments on Microsoft Word

4.1.5 Activities

4.1.5.1 Activity 1: Example of coding

Have a look at this example of coding (using Thematic Analysis) from Braun & Clarke (2013)

Think about the following:

Do you agree/disagree with the codes that the authors have chosen? Which ones, and why? Are there any additional codes that you think might be worthy of consideration?

4.1.5.2 Activity 2: Try it yourself!

It's time to have a go at coding yourself now!

Read through this transcript, taking brief notes individually the first time you read it. What things did you pick up?

A possible research question for this transcript is: *How do students make sense of why people get tattoos and piercings?*

Check your codes before you post

- Is each code a short label, rather than a summary of what the participant said?
- Does each code capture one idea?
- Is each code relevant to the research question?
- Are all of your codes semantic? If so, read the transcript again and look for anything less explicit. You do not need both kinds, but you should notice which approach you are using.

Identify codes for this transcript and post them on the padlet. Ashley will then give class-wide feedback on the codes to the class.

4.2 Developing themes (Phases 3-6)

Here, we'll focus on Phases 3 to 6 of the process. We also covered how to do Phase 3 in the Thematic Analysis lectures in Semester 1. For these activities, you are welcome to do them individually or in pairs/small groups – whichever you prefer!

4.2.1 Phase 3: Generating initial themes (p.78)

In this stage, you should sort the codes into potential themes. Here, you will start to analyse your codes, and consider how they might share an idea or concept.

It might be helpful to visualise this in some way, and see how the codes fit together. You may have codes that don't seem to fit anywhere, others will fit neatly into themes, others might be in sub-themes.

You end this step with a collection of candidate themes (and potentially sub-themes).

Practical Steps

- Start to group your initial codes together
- Can you see a pattern of shared meaning across different codes?
- What are the similarities across codes?
- End this stage by collating all the coded quotes relevant to each theme.
- Themes can be descriptive or interpretative (see Braun & Clarke, 2013, Ch 11).
- Using tables or mind maps at this stage can be helpful

4.2.2 Phase 4: Developing and Reviewing themes (p.97)

In Phase 4, you check your themes to see whether they make sense a) when you look at the coded extracts for that theme and b) when you look at the whole dataset.

Checking the coded extracts

Reviewing at the level of the coded extracts. Read all the collated extracts for a theme…do they form a coherent pattern? Do they tell an important story about shared meaning? Are you sure they are themes rather than topic summaries?

If they seem like themes and the coded extracts fit well underneath them, then move on to checking the themes against the dataset.

If they don't, is it the case that a) the theme itself is problematic and needs to be reworked or b) the theme is fine, but some of the data doesn't fit?

Checking themes against the whole dataset

Look across the entire dataset and consider your theme(s) – do they accurately reflect the meanings in the dataset? Do they tell you about the important patterns that you observed in the dataset?

Practical Steps

- It may be necessary to collapse two themes together, to split a theme into two or more themes, or to discard the candidate themes altogether and begin theme development again.
- Not every participant will make specific reference to every theme – that is ok – but think about how each person is represented in the analysis.

4.2.3 Phase 5: Refining, Defining and Naming Themes (p.108)

- During this phase, you should define and refine the themes.
- Define and refine = identifying what this theme is about, what aspect of the data is captured by each theme?
- For each theme, you need to conduct and write a detailed analysis
- Do your themes explain different things without overlapping too much?
- Try to choose names for themes that are not one word or likely to indicate topic summaries (see the Semester 1 Thematic Analysis Lectures if you want to revisit this)

Practical Steps

- This involves being able to explain each theme: 'What story does this theme tell?' and 'how does this theme fit into the overall story about the data?'.
- Identify the 'essence' of each theme and construct a concise, punchy and informative name.

4.2.4 Phase 6: Writing up your Analysis (p.118)

- The analysis should provide a concise, coherent, logical, non-repetitive and interesting account
- The write up must provide sufficient evidence of the theme(s) (this is where the quotes come in!)
- The extracts you choose should clearly illustrate the theme
- Writing up is where you build your narrative around the themes and quotes – see Developing a narrative below for guidance

Practical Steps

- For the RM2 qualitative report, you should report either two themes (no sub-themes) or one theme with 2-3 sub-themes. This is to allow you to balance depth and breadth due to the limited word count.
- Try to include some 'longer' quotes for each theme, and avoid using lots of very short quotes. This will allow you to explore in more depth. You can supplement longer quotes with some shorter quotes.
- Try to remember that the reader (or marker) needs to see evidence of your ideas - the quotes are your evidence.

4.2.5 Activities

4.2.5.1 Activity 1: Try it yourself!

Use the same transcript as for Phases 1-2 – it is linked here. You can use the codes you developed in the coding activity, or you can recode the data again if you prefer – either option is fine.

- Once you have your codes, try to organise them into themes.
- Group together the codes that seem similar in some way – can you think of an overarching 'theme' that describes them?
- Are there any codes that don't 'fit' anywhere? (that's okay if so!)

- Can you identify any quotes that you would use to evidence the themes? Do these definitely match well onto the theme?

Check your themes

There is no single correct set of themes for this transcript, so use these questions to review your own:

- Does each theme capture a pattern of shared meaning, rather than a topic summary (a collection of everything participants said about one topic)?
- Can you explain what each theme is about in one or two sentences?
- Is each theme's name more than one word, and does it tell the reader something about what you found?
- Do the coded extracts under each theme fit together? Are there any that belong somewhere else?
- Do your themes overlap too much? Or are they so unrelated that they do not tell one story about the data?
- Does each theme help to answer the research question?
- Are any of your themes really just the interview questions?

If any of these questions shows a problem, go back to Phase 4. See also Some common problems with thematic analysis in Appendix B.

One possible set of themes

Try the activity and the self-check first. This is one possible analysis of the transcript, not the correct answer: another analyst could develop different themes from the same data, and that would be fine if their themes were well evidenced. These themes are very tentative as they are based on a small excerpt. In a full study, you would need to develop your themes across the whole dataset.

Theme 1: 'They're gonna be there for rest of my life': tattoos need to mean something

Participants presented personal meaning as the main reason for getting a tattoo. The meanings were not consistent from participant to participant: a tattoo might mark a relationship (Rachel's example of a celebrity with her children's birthdays tattooed on her wrist), identity (Mandy had her name in Japanese), stages of personal growth (Jo talked about how her tattoo related to sprituality) or a way of coping (Thomas's 'carpe diem' tattoo). These accounts share the idea that a tattoo has to be *justified*, which is likely related to its permanence. Mandy makes this link herself by saying that they have to 'mean something' to her, as they will be there for the rest of her life.

Piercings were discussed far less. Jo provides an interesting contrast: her tattoos represented spirituality for her, whereas her piercings were 'purely' for sexual gratification.

One tentative interpretation is that because piercings can be removed, they might not be held to the same standard of meaning as tattoos.

Theme 2: 'You can't stop me': body modification as a claim to independence

Several participants linked tattoos and piercings to defiance (especially of parents). This was related to reaching an age where parents could no longer prevent it: David compared it to going to the pub on your eighteenth birthday because you can, and Rachel's sister got her belly button pierced once she turned 16 and told her parents 'you can't stop me'. However, this was not consistent throughout the transcript - although rebellion was not the reason for Thomas's tattoo, he did say that telling his mother 'felt great'. However, claiming independence does not necessarily end parental disapproval: Jo's mother still reacted strongly when she saw Jo's tattoo.

What these themes leave out

These themes take participants' accounts largely at face value, focusing on the reasons and meanings they describe. A researcher aiming for social constructionist knowledge (see Chapter 1) might focus on how the group talked instead: for example, how participants' stories about defying their parents, and the laughter that followed them, present parental disapproval as normal and funny.

Show how these themes were reviewed (Phase 4)

The first set of candidate themes looked different. Three changes were made during review:

- **'Reasons for getting tattoos and piercings' was dropped.** It grouped everything participants said in answer to the moderator's question, so it was really the interview question rather than a theme. It collected data on one topic but did not identify a shared meaning, which makes it a topic summary.
- **'The thrill of getting a tattoo' was merged into Theme 2.** Only Thomas described this, and the thrill he describes comes from telling his mother, so it fits better within the theme about independence from parents.
- **'Piercings for sexual gratification' did not become a theme.** It came from one participant in one line, so there was no pattern. Rather than discarding it, it was used as a contrast within Theme 1, because it helps to show what makes tattoos different.

Codes that do not fit any theme are normal. Remember that every code does not need to make it into your analysis.

4.2.5.2 Activity 2: Bad analysis

This is an additional activity and only if you have time/want to explore a bit further. Have a look at the analysis. This is an example from Braun & Clarke's book. Why do you think it might be considered a poor example of thematic analysis?

After you've finished, you can look at the points that Braun & Clarke identified. Did you identify any additional ones? Were there any you missed?

4.3 Developing a narrative

When doing your thematic analysis, it is important to develop a narrative and go beyond paraphrasing/summarising your data.

Thematic Analysis requires an active approach from an analyst. It is your role to make sense of the data and to present this in a coherent, understandable and accessible way to the reader. You will take these 'patterns of meaning' and make sense of/interpret them, and convey these to the reader. Remember that themes do not emerge (see the start of this chapter): the narrative is something you build, and it reflects your interpretation of the data.

When you present your data in the analysis section, you will have a) your list of themes and b) your quotes. It is your job to combine these with analytical commentary, in order to tell the story of your data. It's not enough to present the themes and then back these up with quotes – your job is to add in a narrative that brings the themes and the evidence (i.e. quotes) together.

Things to be aware of in developing a narrative

1. Remember to introduce your theme to the reader – what is it about? Don't start a theme with a quote. If you have sub-themes, still introduce the overall theme briefly before you discuss your first sub-theme
2. Explain to the reader why you've chosen to include each quote. Why is it important enough to be included? What does it tell us about your data?
3. Focus on depth rather than breadth – it is important that we get a real sense of your theme. In the RM2 report you only have 3000 words in total, and so will have to choose what you discuss
4. Show the reader who each quote comes from – we should be able to match this up with the demographics table/list of interviews in the Methods section (which then gives us some context). You can do this by using pseudonyms and linking this to the table by using the same names there too.
5. Think about where the opportunities are in your data to go beyond description. Is there anything you can infer? If so, remember to be clear with the reader that this is your interpretation. Your reader should be able to see why you have interpreted the data this way from the quotes you've chosen.

4.3.1 Activities

4.3.1.1 Activity 1: Analysing vs. summarising

Read pages 8-12 from this thematic analysis on skin-picking. Here, the authors report three themes and then have a reflection at the bottom. Try to identify where the authors have gone beyond paraphrasing – discuss in your groups/pairs if you can.

4.3.1.2 Activity 2: Evaluating analysis and discussion sections

Do this exercise on evaluating analysis sections of published papers.

If you are planning a qualitative dissertation, the optional research skills session in Appendix B goes into reflexivity, familiarisation and common problems with thematic analysis in more depth.

5 Ethics, rigour and reflexivity

This chapter will help you to consider ethics, rigour and reflexivity in qualitative research. It has three sections:

- **Ethics** – the ethical issues that are particular to qualitative research, and how to address them
- **Rigour** – how the quality of qualitative research is judged
- **Reflexivity** – how your own position shapes your research, and how to reflect on it

The three are connected: research that is carried out ethically is part of good-quality research, and reflexivity is one of the main ways qualitative researchers show the quality of their work.

5.1 Ethics

This section will talk you through the ethical considerations you need to conduct qualitative research. As you remember from RM1, every time we conduct research with human participants, we have to think carefully about the potential impact of our research and we must adhere to the BPS Code of Human Research Ethics. Some of the ethical issues are common to both quantitative and qualitative research (for example, informed consent and the right to withdraw), but due to the nature of qualitative data, there are certain aspects we need to be particularly mindful about.

5.1.1 General ethical considerations

These are some of the things we **MUST** take into account when conducting research on human participants:

- Possible risks to participants (physical and/or psychological)
- The elimination or minimisation of risks
- Justifying risks in terms of the scientific value of the results
- Ethical approval prior to the study
- The right to withdraw
- Informed consent
- Debriefing and aftercare of participants (especially with deception)
- Anonymity and appropriate data management

5.1.2 Activity 1: Identify potential ethical issues

Before opening the answers below, write down what ethical issues each of these elements of qualitative research might have:

- Research questions and interview/focus group questions
- Data collection
- Recording of interviews/focus group
- Anonymity
- Confidentiality

Show possible issues

1. Research questions and interview/FG questions
This might look like: In qualitative research, we often ask about someone's lived experience, or their motivations, or a belief they have. This is quite different to quantitative research where data comes in as numbers and in that sense is less personal.
Why might this be an issue: Qualitative research tends to be on topics where we ask people to be vulnerable and open themselves up to us as researchers. If we don't frame this correctly, our interview schedule might contain questions that are inappropriate and uncomfortable for the participants.
2. Data collection
This might look like: Data collection is much less likely to be anonymous, as typically in-person or online focus groups or interviews are held. Samples are small, and participants may already be known to the researcher.
Why might this be an issue: There are possible issues of confidentiality and anonymity (discussed below). Because samples are small and researchers often meet participants, we are also closely involved in the research: our assumptions might affect the way we frame the questions, how we interact with participants, and how we interpret the data. In qualitative research, this is not treated as 'bias' to be removed, but as something to reflect on openly (see Reflexivity).
3. Recording of focus groups/interviews
This might look like: The majority of the time, focus groups and interviews are recorded (either audio + video or audio only). This means that the 'raw' data - as it were - is identifiable. In contrast, data for quant studies are often collected anonymously.
Why might this be an issue: Data should **always** be kept safe and secure. However, with qualitative data, there is a real risk that individual people could be identified from a recording of them. This means that recordings must be handled safely and securely, and that transcripts must be anonymised so that participants cannot be identified from them.
4. Anonymity
This might look like: In quantitative research, we tend to report summary statistics from groups, and therefore it'd be quite unusual to be able to identify a single participant from

the data. With qualitative, it's a bit different. We collect people's words and experiences.
Why might this be an issue: It is easier to identify someone from the words they use, and the situations and circumstances they describe.

5. Confidentiality

This might look like: In a focus group or interview, people might be very open with us, and tell us things about their life, and the lives of others.
Why might this be an issue: We have a duty of care to keep what participants tell us confidential. However, there are limits: if a participant says something that suggests they or someone else is at risk of serious harm, the researcher may need to pass this on (this is known as safeguarding). Participants should be told about these limits before they take part. In a focus group, we can ask participants to keep what is said within the group, but we cannot guarantee that they will. Participants should be told this too, so that they can decide what to share.

How would you reduce these risks? For each of the five issues, write down at least one thing a researcher could do. Then compare your ideas with the suggestions below.

Show some ways to reduce the risks

These are examples, not a complete list. You may have thought of others.

- **Research and interview questions:** ask a supervisor or ethics committee to review the questions, and pilot them if possible; let participants decide how much to share, and remind them that they can skip any question; plan what to do if a participant becomes distressed, and signpost support services.
- **Data collection:** think carefully before recruiting people you know or have power over (for example, your own students or colleagues), and reflect on how the relationship might affect what they say; reflect on your own assumptions (see Reflexivity).
- **Recording:** ask for consent to record specifically; record audio only if video is not needed; use encrypted devices and university-approved storage; delete recordings once they have been transcribed, as set out in the data management plan.
- **Anonymity:** use pseudonyms; remove or change details that could identify someone, including combinations of details (e.g. job title, town and age together); think about who might read the findings, including people who know the participant.
- **Confidentiality:** explain the limits of confidentiality before people take part; in focus groups, agree ground rules about keeping what is said within the group, and tell participants that this cannot be guaranteed.

5.1.3 Activity 2: Information sheet and consent form

Take a look at the (slightly modified) Information sheet and Consent form from a qualitative survey study that had ethical approval from the University. Can you identify where and how the principles listed in the General ethical considerations and Activity 1 are discussed?

5.1.3.1 Information sheet

How do perceived language barriers affect the teachers' experience teaching international students in higher education?

Invitation My name is XX, and I am a student at the University of Glasgow. This study is conducted as a part of my MSc Psychological Studies Dissertation project. You are invited to take part in this study because you are currently teaching international students at a UK-based university. Before you decide to take part, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. If you would like further details about the study before deciding whether you want to participate, please get in touch with us via email (XX@student.gla.ac.uk).

Brief Summary We are looking to learn more about higher education teachers' perceptions and experiences of language barriers. We are recruiting people who are currently teaching and/or supervising international students in a UK-based university. To understand your experience, opinions and thoughts on this topic, we are conducting the study through an online qualitative survey. Some issues which we are interested in learning more about include: 1) the impact of language barriers on teaching and supporting students who speak English as a second language; 2) how teaching staff perceive language barriers affecting them and their students; 3) possible ways to bridge the language barriers at different levels.

What's involved if I agree to take part? We want to support you in deciding whether this research study is suited to you - if upon reading this information sheet, you have more questions, please do not hesitate to contact us. If you choose to take part, we will ask you to provide informed consent, after which you will be asked to complete the survey, which consists of two parts: a brief demographic questionnaire, and six open-ended main questions about your experiences of language barriers in your teaching. The survey should take no longer than 40 minutes to complete, and you may take a break at any point if you wish. Because the data will be analysed using qualitative methods, we ask you to provide a comprehensive account of your experiences, but only to provide as much or as little detail as you feel comfortable sharing. Anonymised (see below) quotes from your responses may be used in the dissertation and other future dissemination to illustrate the findings. If you choose to withdraw from the study at any point, you may do so by simply closing your browser.

Confidentiality: Ways to protect your identity and data We do not want to reveal any personal information about yourself or your colleagues as part of this research. Your responses

are recorded completely anonymously through Microsoft Forms and your name will not be recorded anywhere. Prior to the data analysis, all responses will be screened and further anonymised in case you have provided information which may be identifiable (such as specific course names or institutions). We will take the following steps to make sure that your personal information and particular details of your experiences are not shared.

- Your data will be assigned an anonymous participant ID automatically and password protected on a secure server
- Changing any names, places or organisations you write in your answers.
- All the research data will be securely stored to comply with the General Data Protection Regulation (2018) and only made accessible to future researchers in a form which protects individual, personal information.

What are the possible disadvantages and risks of taking part? The materials do not involve anything that would affect you in a negative way – as explained above, you may share as much or as little detail about your experiences as you feel comfortable doing. You are also free to withdraw from the research by closing your browser at any point without giving any reason why.

Who is organising this research? This research is being conducted as part of an MSc Dissertation. The research is supervised by Dr Wilhelmiina Toivo, Wilhelmiina.toivo@glasgow.ac.uk and the research has been granted ethical approval from the University of Glasgow. If you would like further details about the study before deciding whether you want to participate, please get in touch with us via email.

Many thanks,
XX

5.1.3.2 Consent form

Title of Project: How do perceived language barriers affect the teachers' experience teaching international students in higher education?

Researcher: XX, (Supervisor Wilhelmiina Toivo)

If you agree to participate in this study, then please read the following statements and indicate your consent by ticking the boxes for each statement

- I have read the Information Form for participants and so understand the procedures and have been informed about what to expect.
- I agree to participate in this study, which aims to investigate how perceived language barriers affect university teachers' experiences teaching and interacting with international students who speak English as their foreign language.
- I understand that my participation in this study is voluntary, and that I can withdraw from the study, at any time and for any reason, by closing the browser.

- I understand that my participation in this project is for the purposes of research and is in no way an evaluation of me as an individual.
- I understand that any information given in the investigation will be made and kept anonymous and will remain confidential and no information that identifies me will be made publicly available.
- I understand that anonymous quotes from my responses may be used in academic publications/talks to illustrate the findings.
- I understand that I can contact the researcher for this project by e-mail to receive more information and/or a summary of the results.

Show where the principles appear

This is one way of mapping the principles onto the information sheet and consent form. You may have spotted other places too.

General ethical considerations

- **Possible risks, and minimising them:** 'What are the possible disadvantages and risks of taking part?' sets out the risks. Participants can share 'as much or as little detail' as they feel comfortable with, and can take a break at any point.
- **Justifying risks in terms of the value of the research:** the 'Brief Summary' explains what the study aims to learn and why.
- **Ethical approval:** 'Who is organising this research?' states that the study has ethical approval from the University of Glasgow.
- **The right to withdraw:** 'What's involved' explains that participants can withdraw at any point by closing their browser, and the risks section adds 'without giving any reason why'. The consent form repeats this.
- **Informed consent:** the 'Invitation' asks people to read the information carefully, discuss it with others if they wish and get in touch with questions. The consent form then asks participants to agree to each statement separately.
- **Debriefing and aftercare:** these are usually covered in a separate debrief at the end of the study, so you would not expect to find them in full here. The consent form does tell participants they can ask for a summary of the results.
- **Anonymity and data management:** 'Confidentiality: Ways to protect your identity and data' covers anonymous recording through Microsoft Forms, participant IDs, password-protected storage on a secure server, changing names, places and organisations, and compliance with GDPR.

The elements from Activity 1

- **Research and survey questions:** the 'Brief Summary' lists the issues the study is interested in, so participants know in advance what they will be asked about. 'What's involved' explains the format (a short demographic questionnaire and six open-ended questions).

- **Data collection:** the study uses an anonymous online survey rather than interviews or focus groups. This design choice avoids some of the issues in Activity 1: participants do not meet the researcher or each other.
- **Recording:** there is no audio or video recording, because participants type their answers.
- **Anonymity:** responses are screened and further anonymised before analysis (for example, removing course names or institutions), and only anonymised quotes are used.
- **Confidentiality:** the sheet states that the researchers do not want to reveal personal information about participants or their colleagues, and the consent form confirms that no identifying information will be made public.

What might you add or clarify? This study had ethical approval, and the information sheet covers the main principles. However, no information sheet is perfect. Read it again as if you were a participant: is there anything you would want to know that is not there, or anything that could be clearer?

5.1.4 Activity 3: Using data collected by someone else

For your qualitative report, you will analyse a dataset that other researchers collected and shared (for example, through the UK Data Service). Sharing qualitative data has benefits for openness and reuse, but it also raises ethical questions that are different from those in quantitative research.

Think about the questions below. There are deliberately no answers here: these questions are for you to explore, and they connect to Task 2 of the group portfolio (see Chapter 6).

- When participants agreed to take part, what did they agree to? Would they have expected their words to be read and analysed by other researchers, years later?
- Qualitative data is rich and detailed. How far can it be anonymised before it stops being useful?
- The original researchers knew the setting, the participants and what happened during the interview. What is lost when someone else analyses the transcript without that context?
- Once data has been shared, who is responsible for protecting the participants: the people who collected it, the archive, or the people who reuse it?
- Are some topics or groups of participants more sensitive to reuse than others? Why?

You may find it helpful to look at what the BPS Code of Human Research Ethics says about these questions, and at the information the UK Data Service provides about the dataset you are using.

5.2 Rigour

In quantitative research, quality is often judged by reliability and validity: for example, would another researcher using the same measures get the same result? Reflexive thematic analysis does not aim for this. Because you actively develop your themes (see Chapter 4), another analyst could develop different themes from the same data, and both analyses could be good. Instead, quality is judged by whether the analysis is careful, coherent, transparent and well evidenced.

This means that some quality checks from quantitative research do not fit reflexive TA. For example, measuring how far two coders agree (inter-rater reliability) assumes that there is one correct way to code the data. Braun and Clarke (2021) argue that this does not fit reflexive TA, where the researcher's subjectivity is a resource rather than a problem. Talking your analysis through with other people is still useful, but the aim is to help you think more deeply, not to reach agreement.

5.2.1 Ways of thinking about quality

There are several sets of quality criteria for qualitative research. You do not need to learn them in detail. They are different ways of asking the same question: how would a reader know that this analysis is careful and trustworthy?

- **Yardley's (2000) four principles** are widely used in health psychology: sensitivity to context; commitment and rigour; transparency and coherence; and impact and importance.
- **Tracy's (2010) eight 'big-tent' criteria** are designed to apply across many kinds of qualitative research (hence the 'big tent'): a worthy topic, rich rigour, sincerity, credibility, resonance, significant contribution, ethics, and meaningful coherence. Two of these link directly to this chapter: *sincerity* includes self-reflexivity, and *ethics* is treated as part of quality.
- **Braun and Clarke's (2006) 15-point checklist** was written specifically for thematic analysis. It covers transcription, coding, analysis and the written report.

The table below shows what Yardley's principles might look like in a thematic analysis like yours.

Principle	What it might look like in your analysis
Sensitivity to context	Showing awareness of the context the data came from (especially important when you did not collect it yourself), of relevant literature, and of participants' own perspectives and language
Commitment and rigour	Working carefully through all six phases, engaging with the whole dataset, and giving the analysis enough time

Principle	What it might look like in your analysis
Transparency and coherence	Showing how you did the analysis (for example, evidence of your coding); being clear about the type of knowledge you are aiming for (see Chapter 1) and making sure your analysis fits it; reflexivity
Impact and importance	Showing what your analysis adds: why does it matter for your research question?

For practical ways to build quality into your analysis, such as reflexive journalling and talking about your data with others, see Strategies for ensuring quality in your analysis in Appendix B.

5.2.2 Activity 1: Spot the quality strategies

In Chapter 4 (Developing themes), the activity on the tattoos and piercings transcript has two reveals: 'Show one possible set of themes' and 'Show how these themes were reviewed'. Read both, including the part headed 'What these themes leave out'. Which of Yardley's four principles can you see? Try to find an example for at least two principles.

Show one possible answer

- **Commitment and rigour:** the candidate themes were checked against the coded extracts and changed. A topic summary was dropped, and a theme based on one participant was merged into another.
- **Transparency and coherence:** each change is explained, with a reason, so the reader can follow the decisions. 'What these themes leave out' is open about the type of knowledge the analysis aims for, and what a different approach would notice.
- **Sensitivity to context:** the themes are described as tentative because the transcript is short, and one participant's comment about piercings is kept as a contrast rather than discarded or turned into a theme of its own.

You may have found other examples. As in Chapter 4, this is one possible answer, not the only one.

5.3 Reflexivity

Two terms are often used together:

- **Positionality** is who you are in relation to your research: your background, identities, experiences and values, and how these relate to the topic and the participants.

- **Reflexivity** is the ongoing practice of examining how your position shapes the research: the questions you ask, what you notice in the data, and how you interpret it.

In qualitative research, the researcher's experiences and values are seen as part of the research process (see Chapter 1). Themes do not emerge from the data on their own: you develop them, so your position will shape them (see Chapter 4). Reflexivity does not remove this influence. It makes it visible, so that you and your reader can see how it has shaped the analysis. This applies whatever type of knowledge your study aims to produce: in reflexive TA, a realist analysis needs reflexivity as much as a social constructionist one.

We ask you to think about your own position in the research as part of your report (there is a section in the Method, and you need to include a reflexivity diary as an appendix to your report).

This can be quite tricky to do, but is very important for qualitative research. Some suggestions to get you started:

- Think about the topic you are doing for your research and your position in it. Where would you place yourself in relation to it?
- What are your own views on the topic? Do you feel quite strongly about it or not?

Write as you reflect. Writing – be it using pen or pencil on paper, typing on a keyboard, dictating to some voice capture device, or some other mode – is an important tool for developing reflexive depth.

Start with your own experiences, understandings and views, but then also try to interrogate those (i.e. why do you have these particular understandings, views etc.?)

Some questions that you might ask yourself:

- What do I expect to come up in the data? How does this relate to what we found?
- What broader experiences have I had that might influence how I'm thinking about this?
- What are my values (i.e. what is important to me)?
- What about my beliefs? How might these have influenced my thinking?

5.3.1 When to reflect

Reflexivity is not a one-off task at the end of a project. It helps to stop and write at different points:

- **Before you start:** what do you expect to find, and why?
- **When you first read the data:** what is familiar or surprising, and why are you reacting to the data in that way? (Phase 1 in Chapter 4 asks you to note this.)
- **While coding and developing themes:** which parts of the data are you drawn to, and which are you passing over? Can you see your own views in your themes?

- **When writing up:** does your interpretation go beyond what the data supports? Would someone with a different background read the data differently?

5.3.2 Activity 1: Reflect on a topic

First, choose a topic to reflect on. Here we have some data from Braun & Clarke – there are different datasets to choose from. If you want to use the ones from Braun & Clarke, you can either choose the 'childfree' dataset or the 'healthy eating' dataset. However, we know that some topics might be difficult for people, so please do choose a topic of your own preference if you would rather – any qualitative dataset (e.g. from UK Data Service) or news article would be fine.

Spend some time reflecting on the topic and where you would place yourself in relation to it, both personally and in terms of more general views. Write as you reflect. Start with your own experiences, understandings and views, but then also try to interrogate those.

Ask yourself questions like:

- What assumptions am I basing my thinking on?
- What broader experiences and values might inform my thinking on this?
- How might these be connected to myself as a person, my various identities, my personal experience in relation to the topic, and the communities I am part of?

5.3.3 Activity 2: Share your experience of reflecting

Discuss your experiences of reflecting with your group. Did you find it easier than expected? Was it harder? Was there anything that surprised you about the process? Please only share what you feel comfortable with.

If you are working on your own, write a few sentences answering the same questions instead, or post them on the Teams channel.

5.3.4 Activity 3: Positionality and your data

This activity has two sections. Section 1 is a broader reflective exercise that you can do at any time. Section 2 is for when you are working with a dataset: either the one you chose for Activity 1, or the dataset for your report once you have it.

Your notes are for you, so only write and share what you feel comfortable with. They can also be a starting point for your reflexivity diary.

5.3.4.1 Section 1: Who are you as a researcher?

This section asks you to reflect on your general position as a researcher: your background, values and what you bring to qualitative work, whatever the project. Jot down a few points in response to each question.

Step 1: Your background and values

- What was your first degree or previous work (for example, in business, law, engineering or the arts)? How might that shape how you approach research?
- Are there groups, communities or topics you feel particularly close to, or particularly distant from?
- What do you expect qualitative research to be like, and what assumptions have you brought to it?

Step 2: What this might mean for your research

- Are there topics or participant groups where your background might lead you to assume rather than explore?
- Are there perspectives you might be less likely to notice or take seriously?
- If you were collecting data yourself (for example, in a future dissertation), how might your identity or position affect how participants respond to you, or how you respond to them?

Step 3: Draft a general positionality statement

Using your notes, write 3–4 sentences that describe who you are as a researcher and what you bring to qualitative work. Then check your draft: could it apply to almost any researcher? If so, what could make it more specific to you?

Compare with an example

This example comes from a more experienced researcher writing about a specific study, but it shows the difference between a weak and a stronger statement.
A weak statement:

> As a researcher I am aware that my background may have influenced the analysis. I have worked in this area for several years and this may have affected my interpretation of the data. I tried to be aware of this throughout the research process.

A stronger statement:

> As a practising clinician with fifteen years of experience in this setting, I came into this research with existing assumptions about how hierarchy and

communication work in practice. Being an insider to the research topic meant I may have taken certain things for granted that someone else might have questioned, so I regularly discussed my interpretive decisions with a colleague to check my thinking. One of these conversations led me to reframe a theme I had initially named 'poor communication': my colleague proposed that this reflected my clinical perspective, and the data actually suggested that there was something to pay attention to that was related to power dynamics.

What the stronger version does

What it does	What it looks like	Why this matters
Names a specific background and the assumptions it brought	'fifteen years of experience in this setting … existing assumptions about how hierarchy and communication work'	The reader knows what the researcher brought, not just that they brought something
Identifies an insider position and its risk	'may have taken certain things for granted that someone else might have questioned'	Shows how the position could shape the analysis
Describes what the researcher did	'regularly discussed my interpretive decisions with a colleague'	Reflexivity is something you do, not just something you are aware of
Shows a change in the analysis	'poor communication' was reframed as something about power dynamics	The clearest evidence that reflexivity shaped the findings

The weak version could apply to almost any researcher. It says that the researcher's background 'may have influenced' the analysis, but not how, and 'I tried to be aware of this' does not tell the reader what was done.

5.3.4.2 Section 2: Your position in relation to your dataset

For your report, you will analyse data that someone else collected. You will not have met the participants, and they will not have met you. This changes some of the reflexive questions: as well as thinking about your own position, think about the distance between you and the data.

Step 1: Your relationship to this data

- What is your personal or professional background in relation to this topic?

- Did you have expectations about what you would find before you started? If so, where might these have come from?
- Are you an insider or an outsider to the group or context in the dataset (for example, in age, culture, country, language or experience of the topic)?
- What do you know about how, when, where and why the data were collected? What do you not know – for example, the setting, the relationship between the interviewer and the participant, or what happened before the recording started?
- Are there places where you might be filling gaps in participants' accounts with your own experience or assumptions?

Step 2: How this has shaped (or might shape) your analysis

- Are there aspects of the data you have been particularly drawn to, or particularly likely to overlook?
- Did anything in the data surprise you? Why might this have been? What might it tell you about your assumptions going in?
- Looking at your codes or themes, can you see your own perspective reflected anywhere?

Step 3: Draft a study-specific positionality statement

Using your notes, write 3–4 sentences about your position in relation to this dataset. Aim to be honest and specific rather than generic.

Compare with an example

This example is on a different topic. Imagine a student analysing an archived dataset of interviews with first-year international students about homesickness (the topic you met in Chapter 1).

A weak statement:

> As an international student myself, I may have been biased when analysing this data. I tried to stay objective throughout the analysis.

A stronger statement:

> I moved to the UK to study, and my own first term was difficult, so I came to this dataset expecting accounts of struggle. When I reread my familiarisation notes, I noticed that I had coded almost every mention of family as 'loss'. Going back to the data, I found that several participants described daily calls home as a source of strength, and this became part of my second theme. Because I did not collect the data, I only had the transcripts, so I tried not to fill gaps in participants' accounts with details from my own experience.

What the stronger version does

What it does	What it looks like	Why this matters
Is specific to this study	'my own first term was difficult, so I came to this dataset expecting accounts of struggle'	Links the student's experience to a particular expectation about this data
Describes an action during the analysis	'When I reread my familiarisation notes, I noticed…'	Shows reflexivity as something done throughout the analysis, not only at the end
Shows a change in the analysis	'calls home as a source of strength … became part of my second theme'	Shows the reader how reflexivity shaped the findings
Acknowledges the distance from the data	'Because I did not collect the data, I only had the transcripts'	Shows awareness of what secondary data can and cannot tell you

The weak version uses the words 'biased' and 'objective'. In reflexive TA, your subjectivity is not a bias to be removed (see Chapter 1): the aim is to show how it has shaped your analysis. The weak version could also apply to any international student analysing any data.

! Use your own words

These examples are for practice. In your own report, your reflexivity section must describe your own position and your own analysis, in your own words.

5.3.4.3 After Section 1 or 2: discuss or reflect

Discuss these questions with your group, or write a few sentences in response if you are working on your own:

- How did you find the process of being reflexive?
- Is your statement specific to you and your study, or could it apply to almost any researcher?
- Where else in a write-up might reflexivity appear, beyond a positionality statement? How could you make it visible throughout?

5.3.5 Going further (optional)

Ashley's optional research skills session in Appendix B has more reflexivity probes and tips, and an activity in which you compare your familiarisation notes on a data extract with Braun

& Clarke's.

Part II

Summative Submissions and Academic Writing Support

6 Group project

6.1 What is the group project?

In the group project, you will engage in three tasks that are designed to help you build your practical research skills in qualitative research. You will compile your answers to the tasks into a portfolio that you submit to Moodle as a group. Please refer to Moodle (Semester 1 Week 14) for a video overview of the project, and make sure that you have engaged with the Assessment Information section of the group portfolio (available on the Assessment section of Moodle) before starting any work on it so you know what to expect.

To help you balance the different assignments in RM2, we have compiled a suggested timeline to help you is a suggested timeline for the qualitative portfolio and report

6.2 Getting to know each other in groups

This section is designed for you to engage with your group early, get to know each other, and develop some common guidelines for working together before you embark on the group project. If you haven't done so yet, please get in touch with your group now to complete the following activities. We have also provided a checklist of things to complete as a group before the start of semester 2.

6.2.1 Getting organised in groups checklist:

- Get in touch with group and make a group chat on Teams
- Introduce yourselves
- Post group introduction on RM2 channel
- Set up a regular check-in time and/or meeting with group
- Discuss group agreement and decide together on items to include
- Submit group agreement to Moodle (individually)
- Read effective group work document and discuss your strengths as a group
- Download the group work template and assign tasks

6.2.2 Activity 1: Create a group chat and set up an initial meeting

Get in touch with your group and create a Teams chat. You **MUST** use Teams for all communication about the group project. Do not use any other platforms (such as Whatsapp, WeChat, Facebook etc.) as these can lead to people being excluded. Set up a meeting in which you will discuss Activity 3 from this chapter. After the initial meeting, set up a regular check-in time. This doesn't necessarily need to be a meeting every time, you can also do it over text. You will need to coordinate between time zones/work calendars/other responsibilities

DO: Communicate regularly and be clear about where and how you are going to communicate about the group project. Be proactive if you are having a busy time and let your group know.

DON'T: Disappear and stop talking to your group if you're having a hard time (if something happens and you don't feel comfortable sharing with your group, you can let the course leads know). Don't agree to meeting times that don't suit you.

6.2.3 Activity 2: Introductions

Introduce yourself to your group members on your Teams chat. In your introduction, tell your group where you are based, which parts of the degree you have enjoyed the most up to date and what is your favourite R function. As a group, find one *non-psychology/university related thing that you all have in common* and share that on the RM2 Teams channel in the thread. Bonus points for the most random common thing!

6.2.4 Activity 3: Group agreements

We appreciate that group work can be challenging (and even more so if you are spread all over the World!) and we want to support you to have an enjoyable and educational group work experience. To that end, we would like each group to create a group agreement that all members sign. We also ask that you complete a task allocation and upload this with your agreement (they are in the same template). The purpose of this is for the group to come together and establish common ground and some rules that each of the group members is committed to. It also means that the group begins working with clearly allocated roles and tasks. This is not to mean that you cannot change tasks later, but it is helpful to set expectations from the outset.

You can download the group agreement template.

Then look at the list of potential items to include below, and as a group, discuss which items you want to include in addition to the standard ones provided, and if there are any you would like to edit or add outside of this list. You will be able to find a sample list of tasks to include for the task allocation in Appendix 1 within the template.

Work on a collaborative document on OneDrive to create your group work agreement and task allocation, and once the group is happy with their agreement and initial tasks, each group member should submit it to Moodle individually (on the Formative Activities tile). ***Please submit your group agreement by the end of week 14 of semester 1.*** If you haven't submitted your agreements and task allocation, we will be in touch to check up on your group.

Group agreement items

Here is a list of items you may want to discuss with your group and add to the group agreement:

- We all agree to establish a common timeline for the project and discuss any deviations from the timeline together as a group
- We all agree to communicate with each other openly and honestly about the project and get in touch with the course leads in the event of an unsolvable group conflict.
- We all agree to respect each other's individual ways of working and discuss these openly as a group.
- We all agree to respect diversity in our group. This includes cultural differences, neurodiversity, different work/life situations and may manifest in different ways of working/approaching tasks.
- We agree to discuss our strengths as a group and divide tasks accordingly.
- I agree to stay in touch with the group and communicate as established by the group. If I am struggling and I do not feel comfortable sharing that with the group, I will get in touch with the course/programme leads for support
- We all agree to meet on a regular basis as established by the group. If I cannot make a meeting I agree to communicate this openly with my group and get in touch to catch up about things I have missed.
- We agree to plan out the individual contribution of each team member in advance before group work starting and openly communicate any changes that may arise during the project.
- We agree to establish the best method of communication for our group that's inclusive and takes into account everybody's individual needs.

6.2.5 Activity 4: Read the Effective Group work document

This document can be used as a checklist to do the group work for your qualitative portfolio. Give it a read and then discuss it with your group once you have your initial meeting.

6.2.6 Activity 5: Assign tasks

Work back from the deadline to establish tasks and when they need to be done. Discuss your strengths and what each person in the group would like to do.

6.3 Qualitative portfolio guidelines and materials

You will complete three tasks: Qualitative questions (Task 1a and 1b), Ethics (Task 2) and Terrible focus group (Task 3). Below, you will find information and the required materials to complete each task. Please use this template to complete your submission.

6.3.1 Task 1a: Qualitative questions

Below, you will find a brief overview of a study topic. In this task, we would like you to imagine that you are collecting data for this qualitative study. A variety of different data collection methods are possible (e.g. interview, focus group, open-ended survey questions). Thinking about the topic and research question presented below, please develop **SIX** questions that you would ask your participants to gather data on the topic of interest. Your questions should be open-ended, clear, concise and appropriate, and the order that they are presented in should make sense. Your aim is to develop questions that would be likely to generate open discussion and rich responses from participants.

Please note: This section (1a) does not contribute towards the 1000 word count for the assessment.

Study overview

Universities provide support for students, and this support can come in many forms, from free counselling services to well-being advisors (Raunic & Xenos, 2008).
In one study, it was reported that only 3% of students used their university counselling service, and only 5% of those who were characterised as vulnerable based on questionnaire scores, used the services (Cooke et al., 2006). This suggests that the majority of students did not make use of services available.
There are many reasons why students may not choose to seek help, including being unaware of services, low socio-economic status, being from different cultural background, embarrassment about having to seek help, and scepticism about the services (Eisenberg et al., 2007; Gulliver et al., 2010).
Another issue around seeking support is that many who do chose to get help, have to wait long periods for appointments (Mowbray et al., 2006). In a recent article reported in the Independent, a waiting time of 4 months was cited for some universities. These delays to support, can lead to emergence of mental health crises situations. Unfortunately, in this the University of Glasgow had one of the longest wait times for counselling (Buchan, 2018).
Research question: What are student's views on how universities can support students and their mental health needs?

6.3.2 Task 1b: Qualitative questions reflection

For task 1B, please reflect on your experience of generating the questions in task 1A. Do you think they would achieve what you want to achieve? Why or why not? Was it easier or harder than you expected? Please link to the evidence base in your answer (suggested word count: 250 words)

6.3.3 Task 2: Ethics

With the Open Science movement, the use of Open, secondary datasets has become a more popular way of conducting research. You've learnt about the importance of Open data in terms of reproducibility and replicability for quantitative research in RM1 - however, the benefits and challenges of Open data are quite different in qualitative research and there are a number of ethical issues associated with sharing qualitative research data openly. For task 2 of your portfolio, we would like you to **identify one ethical issue** associated with the sharing and/or use of open qualitative data, and discuss why it is an issue, and how it could be mitigated. In your response, you should cite relevant literature on the use of open qualitative data, as well as the BPS code of Ethics (suggested word count 250 words)

6.3.4 Task 3: Focus group gone wrong

Here is a short video from a fictional focus group that is conducted very badly (*please note this video is created only for the purposes of this assessment, is not from a real focus group, and should not be shared outside of this course!*).

Your task is to **identify two or three issues with how the focus group is run** and discuss why they are problematic and outline possible ways to improve them. In your response, you should cite relevant literature to support your ideas.

Access the Focus Group gone wrong recording

6.3.5 Where to get guidance for the portfolio tasks?

You should make sure you are up to date on Ashley's lectures on qualitative research. Further, some of the chapters in this book have activities and information which will be helpful in completing the portfolio:

- Chapter 2 on Qualitative questions
- Chapter 3 on Data collection
- Chapter 5 on Ethics, Rigour and Reflexivity

7 Academic writing

This chapter has some activities to help with your academic writing.

7.1 Evaluation in introductions

The activities in this section are designed to help you improve your evaluation in the introduction of your RM2 report (and your dissertation). To re-cap from RM1, the purpose of your introduction is to provide a rationale for your study and answer the **WHY** question; why is your study worth doing? You want to sell your idea to the reader, using existing literature to show how you are building on the evidence that is there.

Although 'identifying the gap' is something that is often key in quantitative research, building a rationale is not exactly the same in qualitative research. This is because qualitative research tends to be very much situated in the context of the particular study (i.e. why is this particular research topic or question important in this context/with this group). Regardless of whether you include a gap or not (you still can), you should convey to your reader **why** your study matters (or why a gap you've identified is important to explore).

Things to do and things to avoid

1. Avoid doing one study per paragraph – instead, build your arguments using multiple sources
2. Avoid describing previous studies in a lot of detail – instead, show how your study builds on them
3. Avoid critiques that your study cannot answer - instead, focus on aspects that your study will address
4. Just because something is never done before, doesn't make it worth doing; show with evidence why we should do the study.

Here are paragraphs from an imaginary introduction to a qualitative study investigating postgraduate students' confidence in their zombie apocalypse survival.

For each, you can click on them to have a look in depth.

Show me Example 1: Using one source, writing descriptively

A study by Lane and Karin (2011) looked at zombie apocalypse survival confidence levels in undergraduate students. The sample consisted of 25 participants (20 male and 5 female), recruited through convenience sampling. The study employed involved a survey comprising Likert-scale questions designed to measure participants' self-assessed confidence in various survival skills. Additionally, participants were asked about their exposure to zombie-related media. The data were subjected to t-tests and regression analyses, and the authors' found that the biggest predictor of zombie apocalypse confidence was exposure to zombie-themed video games.

This paragraph uses just one source, and describes the study in a lot of detail. Instead, it would be better to synthesise evidence from multiple studies and focus on what the findings mean, rather than being descriptive about the studies. Something like:

A study by Lane and Karin (2011) found that the biggest predictor of zombie apocalypse survival confidence levels in undergraduate students was exposure to zombie-themed video games. Miller and Williams (2023) had similar findings, but exposure to zombie films was also a significant predictor of confidence. This suggests that simulation through media is an effective way to increase self-efficacy towards an unknown threat, which has also been found with alien attack research (Ripley, 2017).

Show me Example 2: Making criticisms that are outwith the scope of your study

It should be noted that the majority of studies on zombie apocalypse survival confidence have looked at samples that consist of mostly men (Lane & Karin, 2011 but see also Grimes & Dixon, 2019), and that previous samples have been small.

This paragraph makes a criticism that the study cannot address - issues with sample size are not something that we can address with qualitative designs.

Instead, to create a stronger rationale, it would be better to focus your critical evaluation on aspects which your study actually builds on:

While evidence on the behavioural predictors of zombie apocalypse confidence is robust, the majority of research (see Anderson, 2014) has focused on the exposure time to media and survival skills training. Hence, we lack understanding of how participants perceive their confidence beyond simulation experiences.

Show me Example 3: Why is your study worth doing?

To date, there has been only one qualitative study on the topic – Seok (2013) collected data through semi-structured interviews, which were analysed using thematic analysis and two themes, "Survival mode" and "Confidence through skills" were identified. This study looked at undergraduate students; there is no previous literature on postgraduate students' perceptions of their apocalyptic confidence. Therefore, this qualitative study investigates

the perceived confidence of postgraduate students in their abilities to survive a zombie apocalypse.
Just because it's never been looked at doesn't automatically mean it should be - show with evidence why and how you would expect your new sample/method/something else about the study to differ from previous research and why it's worth exploring:
Previous research has looked at undergraduate students; however, it has been suggested that postgraduate students would be the group most at risk during a zombie apocalypse (Williams, 2021), but also that apocalyptic self-efficacy decreases with age (Anderson, 2004). This suggests that postgraduate students are the most mentally and physically vulnerable group during a zombie apocalypse, and hence it is important to understand their perceptions of apocalypse confidence, and the lack of thereof.

7.1.1 Activity 1: RM1 feedback

Go back to your feedback from RM1 and see what your marker has said about the evaluation ILO and comments for your introduction. List two things that you did well, and two things you want to improve for RM2. If you would like to discuss the feedback and possible improvement points further, you can pop to Wil's or Ashley's office hours.

Quite often what we see is students engaging with a lot of literature in the intro (which is good!), but not really building a rationale or explaining with evidence why the study is worth doing. We want you to move beyond describing the research to critically evaluating it to show how your study expands on existing knowledge.

7.1.2 Activity 2: Top tips and rationales in published papers

Tip 1: Show how your study builds on existing literature When you are building your rationale, try to use multiple studies to show your reader what the current context of the literature is, and how your study is expanding that knowledge. What new is your study bringing? How is it expanding on existing studies?

If you look at these paragraphs from Robertson et al. (2018), they are building the rationale for their study by showing how it expands on existing literature:

Building a rationale

"Kerns and Kendall (2012) published an updated review of the prevalence of anxiety in individuals with ASD, and all studies fell within White et al. (2009)'s original range for anxiety symptoms (11–84%). It should be noted that, of the 24 studies included in the review, only two reported data for individuals older than 19 years of age (Bakken et al., 2010, Hofvander et al., 2009), which illustrates the need to also focus on adults with ASD

in future research (Howlin, 2000)."
"Secondly, as far as we are aware, there have been no qualitative studies investigating anxiety in autism using semi-structured interviews. Although focus groups and interviews are both good data collection methods for qualitative data, there is evidence that individual interviews tend to elicit a broader range of discussion points (Guest, Namey, Taylor, Eley, & McKenna, 2017). Again, this further extends the previous investigation conducted by Trembath et al. (2012)."

Tip 2: Focus your criticism

When you are critically evaluating studies in your introduction, make your criticism focused on things that your study is addressing. This helps you build the rationale. For example, for the RM2 report, don't focus on the sample size and generalisability of existing studies in your introduction, because these are not things that your study will actually be able to address. Instead, focus on gaps/problems your study can address.

If you look at this paragraph from Toivo & Scheepers (2019), they are identifying a gap/problem in existing literature and showing how the new study is addressing this:

Focusing cricitism

"A potential issue in the above SCR studies (as well as in some of the cognitive studies discussed earlier) is that the stimuli were not very tightly controlled in terms of lexical variables (length, frequency, abstractness, etc.), or in terms of syntactic/pragmatic complexity when multi-word phrases were used. This, again, introduces a number of potential confounds (both within and across languages), making it difficult to separate effects of emotional resonance from those related to cognitive effort in word processing. In the present study, we aimed at eliminating such potential confounds by matching our stimuli on a number of lexical variables–as was done in the ERP studies discussed above [22, 23]–and by avoiding the use of translation equivalents."

Tip 3: Draw arguments from related topics.

Sometimes if your topic has not been studied much, it might be difficult to create an evidence-based rationale for your research question. In this case, you can draw logical parallels from related topics/domains. Remember to explain to the reader why you would expect the findings to generalise across the related topics.

If you look at this paragraph from Mahrholz et al. (2018), it acknowledges that evidence on what they are looking at is scarce in voice perception, but the same effect has been found in face perception:

Drawing arguments from other topics

"Similarly, looking at reliability of personality traits across presentation durations, Willis and Todorov [40] found that ratings of trustworthiness, competence, likeability, aggressiveness, and attractiveness for faces, showed moderate to strong positive correlations after 100 ms, 500 ms, and 1000 ms, when compared to ratings made without time constraints. Only participants' confidence in their own judgements increased as a function of duration. Likewise, again using photographs of faces, Bar et al. [33] reported medium positive correlations between ratings at 39 ms and 1700 ms. The authors indicated that the lower threshold was sufficient for reliable assessments of threat but not intelligence, supporting the theory that rapid first impressions serve as a mean of self-preservation and help determine appropriate approach-avoidance behaviour [1, 33, 38]. The idea being that it should not require much information to decide whether a stranger is friend or foe. Finally, Todorov and colleagues [39] obtained a similar finding, again for faces, showing 33 ms of exposure to be sufficient to distinguish between trustworthy- and untrustworthy-looking stimuli. Whilst correlations with control ratings improved between 33 ms and 100 ms, increased exposure duration did not significantly increase the correlations.
In voice research, though there are limited studies that consider the reliability of personality judgements across varying lengths of stimulus types, similar findings have been shown as in face research."

7.1.3 Activity 3: Active reading

When you are reading journal articles, make sure to take notes and think of how each article can be used to build your rationale in the introduction. Here is a resource you can use to help structure your notes about the studies you are going to use for your introduction.

7.2 Evaluation in your analysis section

7.2.1 Activity 1

Complete this activity to improve your evaluation for your thematic analysis, (as well as the discussion section). You may have already completed this as a part of your Data analysis chapter, but if you haven't please do it now. We ask you to compare two published papers against some of the qualitative report ILOs.

7.2.2 Activity 2: Going deeper in your analysis

One of the characteristics of a strong analysis section is that the writer demonstrates an ability to go beyond paraphrasing/summarising. This activity is designed to help you understand

what might be involved in doing so.

Read the following two extracts from an Analysis section and discuss these questions:

1. Which of the two examples is better? Why?
2. What have the authors done that makes the analysis better?

Extract 1 - from a study about the impact of the COVID pandemic

Sarah spoke of using her leisure time to plan and fantasise about her wedding:
"it's enough of a fantasy… it's meant to be stressful, but it's really just been fun. It's like such a nice break from this humdrum life we're living in right now" (Sarah: lines 459-461).
Organising a significant life event seems to be viewed as granting Sarah an escape from her current monotony. While she refers to it as a "fantasy", potentially given uncertainty of the pandemic's progression, she appears to perceive this as constructive and realistic for her future self. Alternately, Mandy's leisure activity involved impossible daydreams:
"I started daydreaming more ridiculous stuff… I know it's never going to come true 'cause it's not real, but it still entertains me" (Mandy: lines 443-444)
While Mandy seems to be under no illusion that her daydreams are feasible, daydreaming impossible scenarios appears to provide more of a release than realistic situations that are subject to ever changing government regulations (e.g. travel bans) that may fall through.

Extract 2 - from a study about social media use during the pandemic

Some participants said it was difficult to fall asleep at night, including those who knew they should fall asleep but could not (*"if I can't stay up and can't sleep"- Sarah*), or participants subjectively thought that they did not need sleep or did not want to fall asleep (*"I am not really able to sleep at night, or like, sleep isn't really needed."* -Andrew)
Participants said that they used social media but that it was only positive at certain points:
I feel like TikTok was fun in the first lockdown during the summer,'cause of all this summer content I guess, but after that it really went downhill. I don't know like, OK personally I deleted all my apps about three weeks ago (John)
John tells us here that he deleted all his apps, because they all went 'downhill'. Tik Tok was helpful during the first lockdown, but not after it.

Show me the answer

Example 1 (COVID):
This is the better example, because it goes beyond paraphrasing. The researcher is analysing the quotes and have engaged with the meaning behind the words. Each quote is selected in a way that helps the author build a narrative of what is happening in the

data
Example 2 (sleep): This is the weaker example, because the author just paraphrases what the participants say. This ends up not adding any real value in terms of analysis, because the reader could just read the quote. The narrative needs to analyse the data and show the reader why they interpret something in a particular way.

7.3 Evaluation in discussions

In this section, we aim to provide some guidance about how to go beyond description in your writing. We will specifically focus on the Discussion section for your RM2 qualitative report here, but you can apply this to other types of writing. In particular, it should be helpful for you as you proceed to your dissertation.

7.3.1 What were your findings?

In your discussion section, start off by telling us what you found in your analysis. However, the key thing to think about here, in terms of evaluation, is to relate your findings to the wider research. It will be likely a good idea to consider on a theme by theme basis (if you are doing themes with no sub-themes) or on a subtheme basis (if you have one theme with 2-3 subthemes).

Some things to consider:

- What did you find? What was your specific contribution?
- Thinking about your findings, what are the similarities and differences from other research findings/theory? Why might this be the case?
- Situate your findings within the broader context - tell the reader about why your findings are important. This can help a reader understand the importance of the results.
- Do your findings challenge existing research? If so, in what way?
- Can you bring in any critical thinking?

7.3.1.1 Activity 1

Read the paragraphs below from Crompton et al., (2020) and think about what the authors are communicating, with a view to considering the points above.

In particular, identify:

- How the authors summarised their results
- The contribution of the themes to the evidence base
- How the authors discuss their results in relation to existing research

- How the authors relate their findings to theory
- How the authors link the findings to 'broader issues'

Study 1: Crompton et al., 2020

This study aimed to examine the experiences of autistic adults spending time with autistic and non-autistic family and friends using a thematic analysis framework. Social relationships are an important, though often complicated, part of autistic people's lives. Previous research has tended to focus on autistic people's relationships with (assumed) non-autistic friends and family. Here, we specifically contrasted relationships across and within neurotypes. The analysis revealed three themes: cross-neurotype understanding, minority status and belonging. The themes help us understand why relationships between autistic and non-autistic people might be so challenging, and how relationships between autistic people are different.
The results align with previous research on the challenges that autistic people face when interacting with non-autistic others, but highlight that interactions with other autistic people are fundamentally different. All participants reported that spending time with non-autistic family and friends involved specific difficulties, which were not experienced when interacting with other autistic friends and family. This aligns with the double-empathy theory of autism which suggests that autistic and non-autistic people have a mutual difficulty in understanding and empathising with one another due to differences in how each person understands and experiences the world, rather than because of a communicative deficit on the part of the autistic person (Milton, 2012). Neurotypical people have been shown to overestimate how ego-centric their autistic family members are (Heasman & Gillespie, 2018), and overestimate how helpful they are to autistic people (Heasman & Gillespie, 2019). Our findings suggest that this translates into real-world difficulties in interactions with neurotypical friends and family that may affect the mental health, well-being and self-esteem of autistic people.

7.3.2 What are the implications of the study?

In addition to theoretical implications you would discuss in a quantitative study, there is scope to discuss broader implications here. Try not to go too far in these implications (e.g. saying that the NHS/University could make changes to how they run mental health services…this would require a much more extensive body of work).

Some things to consider:

- How could these findings be applied to real-life situations?
- What impact might this have for society in the future (even if with the caveat that it would depend on future research)?
- Can you back up your assertions with reference to the literature? Arguments here are much stronger if you are able to cite papers to support.

7.3.2.1 Activity 2

Read the paragraph below from Robertson et al. (2018) and think about how the authors have communicated the implications of the research.

In particular, identify:

- What the implications of the research are
- How the authors link the findings to practical suggestions
- How the authors back up these suggestions to the existing literature base

Study 2: Robertson et al., 2018

There are a number of potential clinical applications for the findings detailed in this paper. They echo the modifications that are already undertaken for anxiety interventions designed for children and adolescents with ASD (Walters, Loades, & Russell, 2016). For example, it may be important to include support for individuals undertaking an intervention for their anxiety. This has already been identified as helpful in anxiety management interventions for children with ASD (Sofronoff et al., 2005), but the evidence here suggests that this might also be the case for adults. Furthermore, as adults reported feeling that they enjoyed interacting with other autistic people, it would be important to test whether running autism-only groups in terms of anxiety interventions helps outcomes or other aspects related to the feasibility of anxiety management programs (e.g. retention of participants).

7.3.3 Limitations

All research will have limitations - there is never going to be a perfect study. Research is about weighing up the options and choosing the best design for the specific question we want to answer. Remember that qualitative research is not automatically limited because it is not quantitative. Therefore, be very careful not to use criteria we have for quantitative studies (e.g. generalisability, reliability, small sample sizes) and apply them to qualitative studies. Doing so would be similar to critiquing a behavioural study for not asking participants about their experience of interacting with the stimuli ;)

Some things to consider:

- Do you think the quality, source, or types of data (or the analytic process) might have affected the methodological integrity in some way? If so, how?
- Remember to link your limitations to the evidence base. This makes your argument much stronger than if you do not cite to back your points up.
- If you want to mention generalisability, perhaps consider the concept of transferability instead, which is much more relevant to qualitative.

- Try to aim for depth rather than breadth here - it's much stronger to have two points addressed comprehensively than have 12 limitations, each covered in a single sentence (you don't want to make your discussion section a limitations-fest!).

7.3.3.1 Activity 3

Read the paragraph below from Toivo & Scheepers (2019). Although this is not a qualitative paper, the following paragraph exhibits many of the strengths noted above.

In particular, identify:

- What was the limitation observed?
- How do the authors discuss this limitation, and consider the effect it might have had?
- How do the authors back up their arguments with evidence from the literature base?

Study 3: Toivo et al., 2019

One concern might be that we did not explicitly control for L2 proficiency in our sample of bilinguals, which is likely to affect cognitive effort in processing L2. However, all of our bilingual participants (a) self-reported to be highly proficient in English, (b) were Glasgow University students using English as their language of study, and (c) had been living in an English-speaking country for minimum of three months (average: two years and four months) when the study was conducted. Together with the fact that post-trial word recognition rates were well above 90% across participant groups and conditions (Fig 2), we do not believe that variation in L2 proficiency was large enough to have a major impact on our results. That said, we agree that proficiency should ideally be controlled for in future research, e.g. by adding a suitable measure as another person-specific covariate in the analyses. Previous research had identified proficiency as a potential mediating factor of perceived emotionality in the Bilingualism and Emotions Questionnaire [50], and it had also been suggested that bilinguals with close-to-native proficiency in L2 show similar affective processing in L1 and L2 [19].

7.3.4 Anything else?

The points above are the key components that we would expect to see in a Discussion section, with some guidance on how to go beyond description. However, you might also consider strengths and future research. It's also good to include a brief conclusion. You won't have the word count available to go into the same detail as in these papers, so try to use the examples above to really focus on what you can incorporate within your Discussion section to strengthen your evaluative writing.

A Qualitative Research Showcases

Throughout RM2, we will showcase some exciting qualitative research which will go beyond what you are taught on the course. For each showcase, we'll provide a couple of research papers for you to look at. You don't need to read these in full (unless you find it interesting and want to!) - the purpose is to give you a little taster of the multifaceted and creative things that can be achieved with qualitative methods. We hope that you find these papers interesting!

A.1 Qualitative research showcase 1 - Alternative data collection methods

On RM2, we mainly focus on "standard" data collection methodologies (interviews, focus groups, qualitative surveys), but much of published qualitative research uses more creative methods, such as art-based approaches (music or photo elicitation, storytelling, collages, etc.), participant-provided diaries, or data scraping. Arts-based approaches allow for data collection which is less formal than an interview/focus group situation might be and they give the participant space to express themselves more freely. Diary studies allow for data collection over time without overburdening the participants, while data scraping is very sueful when working with sensitive topics and/or minority populations that are hard to reach or overburdened by research participation requests.

- Dr Gail Prasad's study explores children's views of plurilingualism through collage-creation. Access the study
- Dr December-Maxwell and colleagues investigate involuntary celibacy through Reddit data. Access the study

Dissertation hint: Data scraping from Reddit (this can be done with R) has been used in previous dissertation projects where primary data collection would be too difficult due to the topic/population, or where a student has wanted to work with secondary data but the topic doesn't have open data available in research databases - keep this in mind for next year!

A.2 Qualitative Research Showcase 2 - Participatory Research

Participatory research refers to the involvement of the groups that are affected by the issue that is being studied. It is becoming increasingly more utilised in qualitative research, and it is

considered good practice particularly in the areas where the studied group is disadvantaged or marginalised. The underlying philosophy of participatory research is to see the people studied not as "subjects" to research, but actively participating stakeholders.

- Drs Vaughn and Jacquez have written an excellent review of the different types and core principles of participatory research. Access the article
- Drs Yaros and Schueller conducted a study on positive computing technologies for children with children as co-creators of the research. Access the article
- Dr Crompton and colleagues studied peer support of autistic young adults in schools with a research team that directly involves autistic stakeholders. Pay particular attention to the Community Involvement section of the article. Access the article

Dissertation hint: If you want to work with marginalised or disadvantaged populations for your dissertation, have a conversation early on with your supervisor about how you might want to incorporate participatory elements into your study. Due to the limited timescale, for dissertations this often looks less fully fledged than what you would see in published papers. For example, for a dissertation, the researcher student might have lived experience themselves, or they might reach out to University networks to find a person with lived experience to review the research question and/or analysis.

A.3 Qualitative Research Showcase 3 - Interesting Analysis Methods

In this qualitative research showcase, we highlight a couple of different types of analyses to give a (very small!) snapshot of the variety of qualitative techniques. Please bear in mind these are beyond what is expected from you on RM2 - don't try to apply these analyses to your report.

- Dr Wilson and colleagues conducted a meta-synthesis of qualitative studies on older adulthood. This is a way to bring together findings from multiple qualitative studies - have a look and see what differences and similarities between this and quantitative meta-analysis. Access the article
- Drs Goodman and Burke conducted a discourse analysis on attitudes to immigrants. Compare and contrast how the analysis is presented and how the quotes are used as opposed to a Thematic Analysis. Access the paper

Dissertation hint: If you are doing a qualitative dissertation, most supervisors will encourage you to do Thematic Analysis because it's highly structured and there is a lot of guidance available. If you are interested in more advanced qualitative analyses, make sure that you have a discussion about this when talking to potential supervisors to identify whether they support this.

B Research skills sessions

Ashley has recorded **optional** research skills sessions on different aspects of qualitative research. These sessions take a deeper dive into some of the topics and may be particularly useful if you are planning on doing a qualitative dissertation next year. Each session has its own section below, with a link to the recording and the activities that go with it.

B.1 Developing questions

Watch the video here

B.1.1 Overall structure

It's important to think about the overall structure of an interview or focus group schedule. A good structure to use is: A warm up question, the main questions you want to ask, and an exit question. It is likely particularly important to use a warm up/ice-breaker question for a focus group, especially if participants don't know each other particularly well.

Warm up Question

The aim is to allow participants to introduce themselves, ensure everyone understands the procedure, and to encourage people to feel comfortable talking. Previous projects have used photos, cartoons, and media, or asked participants to generate meanings of the terms used in the discussion (e.g., "poor sleep", "well-being") to get people talking. *What is your idea for an ice-breaker that might lead naturally into the main discussion?*

What makes a good/poor ice-breaker?

Thinking about the points above: *What do you think of the following ice-breakers?*

- **An FG on lived experience during COVID-19 of international students:** What is your favourite meal from your home country?
- **An FG on coping strategies in students:** What do you think is the best way to reduce stress for students?
- **An FG on feelings of belonging in a work context:** What do you think about the graphic below? Does it resonate in any way?

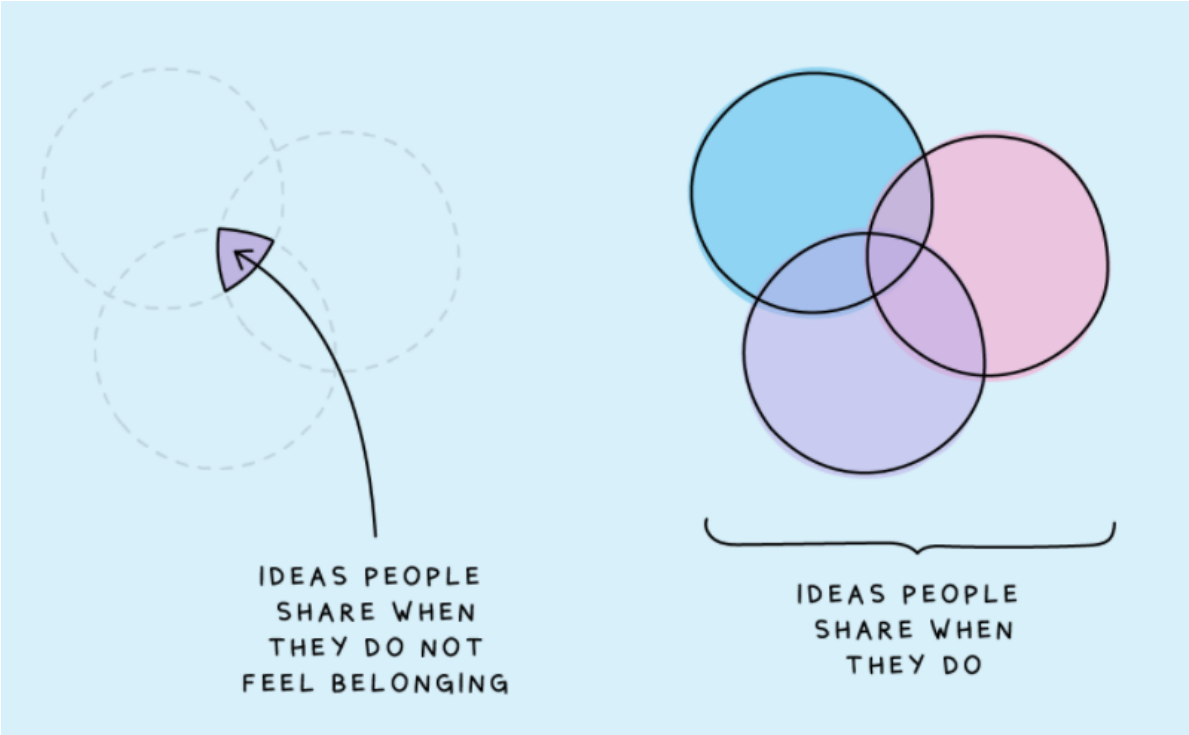


Figure B.1: Belonging ice-breaker

Main Questions

Bear in mind that the discussion may wander off track or focus on one aspect. Consider which part of the research question you think is most important to get people to answer. Start with this and be prepared to come back to it at the end if you need to. If you have more sensitive questions in your research schedule, they should be included later on, so people answer them when they are more comfortable.

What should the questions be like? Avoid asking questions that ask two or three things in one sentence (e.g., about behaviour and impact on mood). Break it down into simpler questions. Limit the number of direct questions that elicit yes/no answers. These can be useful to gather information but are less helpful in generating a discussion. Add in probes/prompts to elicit further information if required.

Try to:

1. Frame questions in an open way that will facilitate discussion (e.g. 'do you use Facebook?' is closed (can be answered as yes/no), whereas 'can you tell me about your experiences with social media?' is a bit more open - you could then follow up with prompts to specifically ask about types if you want to get that information).
2. Frame questions in a way that is not leading. For example, 'how did lockdown negatively impact on your ability to study?' assumes that it did, when this may not be the case. A better question would be "Do you think that lockdown restrictions impacted on students' experiences of studying? If so, how? If not, why not?"
3. If you have sensitive questions, try to frame questions in a way that is not personal (i.e. you give people a chance to answer related to themselves, but they can also choose not to). This approach also invites people who may not have lived experience to respond, e.g. "How do you take care of yourself when you are anxious?" would be better phrased as "How might students support themselves when they are feeling anxious?" This is more important for focus groups, as people might feel put on the spot and go beyond their comfort levels.
4. Avoid asking lots of different things within the one question, e.g. "Can you tell us about your experiences of studying in Semester 1, how it made you feel and how that affects your studying in Semester 2?" You could ask about experiences of studying generally, and then could follow up with specific sub-questions asking them about semester 1 and 2, if that is something that was important to you.

Closing question

The aim here is to give people an opportunity to add anything that might have been missed in the discussion/to wrap things up.

Examples:

- Thank you very much for all the great points you had today! Before we wrap things up, do you have any final points that you would like to make, that perhaps weren't covered in the interview?
- Today we covered X, Y, and Z in the focus group. Is there anyone who has any final thoughts about what we covered here today that they'd like to share?
- That's us finished with the main part of the focus group. We'd like to end by giving you all an opportunity to add anything that you think is important but has not been covered in the focus group so far. If you'd like to add something, please press raise hand on Teams and we can make sure we go round those people before we finish up!

B.1.2 Braun & Clarke (2013) activity

Here, we have an adapted version of an interview schedule that is included in the Braun & Clarke (2013) book, on the topic of Partner Relationships. This is purposefully poor. What problems can you spot?

1. If you are not already married, are you planning to get married within the next few years?
2. I love going to the cinema with my partner, do you?
3. Do you have a good time with your partner?
4. Would you go to Relate if you had problems in your relationship?
5. When and how did you meet your partner?
6. Do you earn more money than your partner?

Show me the solution

This solution is adapted from Braun & Clarke (2013).
In general Overall, the interview schedule lacks coherence – it covers a wide range of different topics, and it's not clear what the focus of the interview is. The ordering of the questions is also very poor (very sensitive questions early in the interview; moving straight from questions about positive aspects of the relationship to relationship difficulties). The researchers should decide on the focus of their research, and their research question, and design the interview schedule with these in mind. The schedule should also be reordered so it starts with less sensitive questions (more sensitive questions should be moved to later in the interview) and the questions flow logically. The interview should also end with a general 'clean-up' question (e.g., 'Is there anything else you would like to add?'). (NB. These answers assume that the research is being conducted in Britain)
Question 1
Problems First, this is a closed question which does not encourage participants to provide rich and detailed answers. Second, unless the researcher already has quite a bit of information about the participant, it is not an ideal opening interview question because it makes a number of problematic and potentially alienating assumptions, which may

damage rapport. For example, unless the study is specifically focused on heterosexual couples ('partner relationships' suggests an inclusive focus), or the researcher already knows how the participants identify their sexuality, assuming that people are married, or asking whether they are planning to marry, reinforces heteronormativity. Furthermore, unless the research is specifically focused on marriage, asking whether people are 'planning to get married' assumes a particular model of relationships whereby marriage (and civil partnership) is treated as the 'gold standard' of relationships, the ideal end-point of a couple's relational journey, and not everyone views marriage in this way (some couples are critical of marriage and choose actively not to get married).
Solutions The question needs to be reworded so that it is inclusive of same-sex and heterosexual relationships and does not 'buy into' assumptions about marriage as gold standard of relationships. The question should also be reworded as an open question and probably moved to later in the interview.

Question 2

Problems Again, a closed question and extremely leading – it invites the participant to agree with the researcher's preferences! This is not the best way of accessing participants' perspectives.
Solutions Reword the question so that it is open and not leading (do not use the researcher's preferences in this way).

Question 3

Problems Again closed, and rather vague (what constitutes a 'good time'?).
Solutions Reword the question so that it is open and more concrete.

Question 4

Problems Again closed, and assumes that the participants know what Relate is (a charity in England and Wales that offers relationship counselling and sex therapy to heterosexual and same-sex couples experiencing relationship difficulties; in Scotland, similar support is provided by Relationships Scotland). Making assumptions about what the participants know (and don't know) can alienate participants (making them feel stupid for not knowing) and damage rapport. Moreover, Relate is not the only provider of relationship counselling in the UK.
Solutions Replace this with an open question and one that does not make assumptions about the participants' knowledge (e.g., 'relationship counselling' is a good substitute for Relate).

Question 5

Problems A double-barrelled question and also one that would work better earlier in the interview.
Solutions Reword the question to remove the double-barrelled element (decide what is more important to know when [how long ago] they met their partner or how they met them?). This would work better as the opening interview question (it makes little sense to ask questions 1-4 before asking this question) because it is a relatively 'gentle' question and possibly one that participants would be expecting to answer in an interview on

partner relationships. It provides participants with an opportunity to 'tell the story' of their current relationship at the start of the interview.
Question 6
Problems Again a closed question and also a very sensitive one!
Solutions Again, this needs to be replaced with a more open question that invites detailed responses. The researcher should reflect on what they want to know and how this question relates to their research question.

B.1.3 Further things to consider with qualitative surveys

1. No opportunity for clarification, so wording has to be clear
2. Similar points to above in terms of not asking too many different things, having a sensible structure
3. No rapport, unlikely to be an 'ice-breaker' (although might have an intro question)
4. People might be more comfortable answering sensitive questions as they can be anonymous
5. Try not to have lots of questions as your participants will likely lose patience - what are the key things you want to know?
6. Can use branching e.g. in Qualtrics

B.2 Data collection

Watch the video here

B.2.1 General tips

- Be organised - get ethics in early etc., keep track of potential participants
- Think through all the different steps involved as you will need to refer to this in your ethics application - how do you plan to recruit, collect the data, store the data? Before you start collecting data, it would be good to have a checklist with everything you need to consider
- Only collect the demographics that you need - if you don't need to know how many siblings they have or what time they go to bed, then don't ask for that information
- Be sensitive to who your participants are - you might ask different questions in a focus group (where people are in front of others) than you would in an online questionnaire (where it is easier to withdraw if uncomfortable).
- Think about how you keep that data safe/anonymous
- Know in advance how many participants you need
- Know how you plan to analyse the data

- Consider what you can do to make the experience as comfortable as possible for participants (e.g. sending out questions in advance is particularly helpful for neurodivergent people/people who do not speak English as a first language).
- For interviews and focus groups - reassert consent before you start & always remember to press record! Also it's normal to feel a bit nervous - try to enjoy the process!
- For all, pilot the questions you ask - make sure that people take from them what you think
- When recruiting, think about who your target group is and it's good to justify why you are looking for a particular demographic. For example, do you definitely require someone to have a particular diagnosis?

B.2.2 Practicalities of running focus groups

- Establish ground rules - esp. confidentiality
- Set expectations - ask participants to respond to each other rather than each person individually responding to the question (if possible, this is not always the case)
- Moderator has to manage the group as best they can
- Wrapping things up.
- Can be helpful to have a notetaker to note down anything interesting/if doing it in person, to note down order that people speak in. Allows the moderator to focus on discussion

Tricky situations

- How do you develop rapport/make people feel more comfortable?
- How do you manage tricky dynamics within a group?
- What if no-one speaks/one person dominates?
- What if people go off topic?
- How to keep people to time?
- Giving everyone who wants it an opportunity to speak - if online could ask people to raise their hand

B.2.3 Practicalities of running interviews

Some of the things that we discussed in focus groups are relevant here, but specifically when thinking about interviews:

- Try to develop rapport and make the participant feel comfortable
- Try to focus on the person rather than taking notes - are you giving them encouragement to keep speaking (e.g. nods etc.)?
- If doing a semi-structured interview, try to notice if the participant brings something up that could/should be followed up with an additional question

- It's usual for some interviews to be shorter than others - some people are very concise in how they answer whereas others talk a lot more (and this may be on topic or not)
- Be aware of how someone is presenting - this is less relevant for coursework and more for future projects - if you are doing quite a sensitive topic, it's good practice to reassert consent and to ask people if they need a break for a little while/if they are okay to continue.
- Try to end on a positive question if you can - it can help to lift the mood for the participant and leave them in a good place

B.2.4 Practicalities of running qualitative surveys

- Think about whether there would be any possibility for the questions to be misinterpreted - you won't have a chance to correct people if they interpret something wrong (this is where doing a pilot can be useful)
- Try not to have too many questions - what are the key things you want to know? People will be less likely to respond with long, in depth answers if there are a lot of questions to answer.
- It might be good to give an indication of how many questions they have to go through.
- Easier to keep data anonymous than it is with other forms of data collection above - however still be sensitive to locations, names, personal experiences as these will have to be anonymised.

B.3 Preparing for data analysis

Watch the video here

B.3.1 Thinking about reflexivity

We ask you to think about your own position in the research as part of your RM2 report (there is a section in the methods!).

This can be quite tricky to do, but is very important for qualitative research. Some suggestions to get you started:

- Think about the topic you are doing for your research and your position in it. Where would you place yourself in relation to it? What are your own views on the topic? Do you feel quite strongly about it or not?
- Write as you reflect. Writing – be it using pen or pencil on paper, typing on a keyboard, dictating to some voice capture device, or some other mode – is an important tool for developing reflexive depth. It is good to do this at various stages of the research process.

- Start with your own experiences, understandings and views, but then also try to interrogate those (i.e. why do you have these particular understandings, views etc.?)

Some questions that you might ask yourself:

- What do I expect to come up in the data? How does this relate to what we found?
- What broader experiences have I had that might influence how I'm thinking about this?
- What are my values (i.e. what is important to me)? What about my beliefs? How might these have influenced my thinking?
- How might all of these be connected to my identities and the communities I am a part of?

B.3.2 Activity 1: Read this extract and take familiarisation notes

Read this extract and take some familiarisation notes for yourself (these are just for you and won't be shared). We will then go through what Braun & Clarke say about it.

Some context:

This activity is based on a data extract from an interview study exploring LGBT students' experiences of university life. The participant is a gay man – a mature student, who spoke English as a second language. The extract comes from early in the interview and in response to a question about whether he is 'out' as a gay man at university – whether he is openly gay.

In this activity (5 mins):

- First, reflect on your assumptions and expectations about this topic, and your positioning in relation to this topic (are you an insider researcher? Outsider?).
- Second, read the data extract and make some familiarisation notes.
- Braun and Clarke's familiarisation notes follow – reflect on similarities and differences in your and their analytic observations and 'take' on the data.

Info

Andreas: …I sometimes try to erm not conceal it that's not the right word but erm let's say I'm in a in a seminar and somebody- a a man says to me 'oh look at her' (Int: mm) I'm not going 'oh actually I'm gay' (Int: mm [laughter]) I'll just go like 'oh yeah' (Int: mmhm) you know I won't fall into the other one and say 'oh yeah' (Int: yep) 'she looks really brilliant' (Int: yep) but I sorta then and after them you hate myself for it because I I don't know how this person would react because that person might then either not talk to me anymore or erm might sort of yeah (Int: yep) or next time we met not not sit next to me or that sort of thing (Int: yep) so I think these this back to this question are you out yes but I think wherever you go you always have to start afresh (Int: yep)

this sort of li- lifelong process of being courageous in a way or not …

Show me Braun & Clarke's familiarisation notes

- Andreas reports a common experience of presumed heterosexuality: coming out is not an obvious option.
- Social norms dictate a certain response; the presumption of heterosexuality appears dilemmatic, and he colludes in the presumption, but minimally (to avoid social awkwardness).

Looking a bit more deeply, Braun and Clarke speculated that Andreas values honesty and being true to yourself, but he recognises a socio-political context in which that is constrained, and walks a 'tightrope' trying to balance his values and the expectations of the context.

B.3.3 Activity 2: A code or a theme?

In this activity, we'll go through a handout that asks you whether something is a code or a theme.

For each label, decide whether it is a code or a theme.

- Keep in mind that although there is no absolute distinction between codes and themes, codes tend to have a single facet and capture one insight or observation about the data, whereas themes are ideally multifaceted and capture several insights and observations. Themes should also capture a pattern of shared meaning – this can be shared meaning on the data surface, or shared implicit or underlying meaning.
- Reflect on why you have decided that each code/theme is a code or theme. What features of the data, the label/name, and brief explanation of the scope and focus of each code/theme influenced your judgement?

Show me Braun & Clarke's solution

Coding label/theme name	Code or theme?
'Natural' gender difference	Code
Men's body hair is natural	Theme
Looks wrong when men remove hair	Code
Animal metaphor	Code
Men's body hair is unpleasant	Theme
Imperative to remove hair	Code
'Ideal' amount of hair	Code
Back hair is ALWAYS excessive	Code
Men's 'excess' body hair needs to be managed	Theme

Figure B.2: Braun and Clarke's suggestions

Three themes were presented in the analysis: "Two themes capture contradictory ideas: that men's body hair is natural, and that men's body hair is unpleasant. A third theme introduces the concept of 'excess' hair, which allowed sense-making of this contradiction, mandating men's grooming of 'excessive' hair." (Terry & Braun, 2016, page 14)

B.3.4 Some common problems with thematic analysis

- Thematic analysis that fails to address the research question.
- Unconvincing or under-developed analysis: 1) Too many or too few themes 2) Too much overlap between themes or themes are unrelated 3) Themes are vague or not internally consistent or coherent
- Little or no analytic work has been carried out (for example, using data collection questions as 'themes').
- Topic summaries being presented as themes
- Mismatch between data and analytic claims (e.g. going beyond what your participants say)
- Too few or too many data extracts (and little or no analytic commentary).

- Paraphrasing rather than analysing and interpreting data
- Arguing with the data – pointing out the 'errors' in a participant's account.

B.3.5 Strategies for ensuring quality in your analysis

Reflexive journalling

Keep reflecting, and writing, throughout the whole research process, not just at the end (see Thinking about reflexivity).

Talk about your data with others

- Discuss your analysis with other people – it helps to clarify your analytic insights
- Do phases 1-2 in pairs if you want
- Discuss your findings in groups
- Come along to office hours
- Present your analysis (even if it's preliminary), this can help solidify where we are going with it

Give yourself time

- Try not to leave the analysis until the last minute
- Give yourself time to step away and breathe
- Perhaps work on other sections of your report at the same time, so that you have a mental break from analysis

Make sure themes are themes (and be careful when naming them)

Connelly and Peltzer (2016, p.55): "When a researcher designated a 1-word theme, such as 'collaboration', what does that mean in relationship to the experiences of the informants as interpreted by the researcher? Using only 1 word as a theme, there is no way of knowing, for example if the experiences of collaboration were positive or negative, or whether collaboration is important to the nurses. One-word themes do not convey what the researcher found out about collaboration"